PART THREE | AN EXPANDING NATION

# CHAPTER 8

# THE EMERGENCE OF A MARKET ECONOMY

1793-1854

## Secondary Source Reader

Historical scholarship for History B17A

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| **INCLUDED** | 51 verified selections from 38 supplied monographs. |
| **SOURCE TEXT** | Continuous passages from supplied editions, with original note calls and corresponding author notes. |
| **CITATIONS** | Chicago Notes and Bibliography; original book locators, never reader page numbers. |

Prepared from the supplied editions.

# Reader's Guide

Each numbered reading is a continuous excerpt from a historian's work. The main heading gives the monograph title; the metadata identifies the verified original chapter or section and the original book locator.

## Citing These Readings

Use the full footnote citation the first time you cite a book and the shortened form thereafter, including when you cite another selection from the same book.

Use original book pages or verified ebook locators, not reader page numbers. Create your own footnote numbering; the superscript numbers within the excerpts belong to the historian.

If a historian quotes a primary source that you have not consulted directly, use a 'quoted in' note. Include only works you actually use in your bibliography.

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CHAPTER 8 · SECONDARY SOURCE S8.01

# The Roots of Rural Capitalism: Western Massachusetts, 1780–1860

Christopher Clark

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| WORK | The Roots of Rural Capitalism: Western Massachusetts, 1780–1860 |
| SELECTION | Introduction |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages 14-15 · Cornell University Press, 1990. |

## Excerpt

Because this book is about social structures and relationships and not purely a quantitative measurement of the growth of markets, it can suggest an explanation of the emergence of rural capitalism. The concept of "capitalism" has given rise to even more debate and confusion than the concept of "markets," so a definition of what is meant by it is essential. In this book I use it to refer to the set of social relations in which labor is commonly divorced from the ownership of the land, tools, or materials that form the means of production; as a result of this, labor power is commonly hired for wages by the proprietors of land or industrial enterprises, and there exists in society a significant number of people whose principal means of livelihood is the wage work that they can obtain. For stylistic reasons, I have used the terms rural capitalism and capitalism interchangeably in places; both refer to the set of social relationships just described. I have used the term rural capitalism, rather than industrial capitalism, to indicate a stage in the development of social relations in the countryside and as a reminder that these relationships came to exist both in manufacturing proper and in farming. I argue that rural society was not, in this sense, "capitalist" at the end of the colonial period but that it had become so by the time of the Civil War. The means by which this happened is the subject matter of this book.

The "transition to capitalism" has long been a subject for discussion; the debate on rural society has helped place it high on the agenda for American social historians. Often, however, scholars have relied on single tests of the existence of capitalism comparable to the one outlined above and have advanced the view that the "transition" was a single set of processes. In what follows I have tried to show that this was not the case. In New England, the emergence of capitalism in the countryside followed a complex and uneven path, hardly reducible to a single stage. Nor, although its achievement was marked by the creation of a permanent wage-labor force, is this the only factor that needs to be traced.

In certain respects, the grounding for rural capitalism had been laid by the early white settlements in New England. Not only had colonization been motivated in part by the desire to profit from New World production and trade, but the establishment of freehold land tenure and the absence of substantial restrictions on the freedom of labor gave New England purer legal and political frameworks for capitalist development than were available in seigneurial or slave societies. But just because there had been a "capitalist" impetus for New England's development did not mean that all settlers were motivated by it, or remained so. Nor did the existence of free land and free labor mean that people would necessarily use them to create capitalist institutions. Many farmers in the interior were more concerned, as we shall see, to establish an independent household economy in which the use of wage labor and production for distant markets were severely curtailed.

Even had market orientation been greater than it was in the late eighteenth century, however, rural New England would not necessarily have been capitalist in character. As scholars of slavery have shown, it is possible to participate in long-distance trade without altering the fundamentally noncapitalist character of a social structure.[18] Only over time, and under circumstances that need to be explored, did market involvement help bring about the creation of capitalist social relations in the New England countryside. Shifts in the exchange system, the use of credit, the emergence of cash and negotiable paper instruments, and the charging of interest on debts, which have also been

taken as the marks of capitalism, all contributed to the process. Produce, capital, and labor markets also reflected, under specific social conditions, the emergence of groups of entrepreneurs capable of securing control of a proportion of the goods, credit, and labor power in the rural economy. Inequalities in the distribution of land and wealth fostered the growth of a population obliged to depend on wage labor. In short, the evolution of rural capitalism was defined, not by the adoption of any one particular set of practices, but by the accretion of a series of distinctive forms and organizations that together came to form a new economic system.

## Author's Notes

18. On the noncapitalist, nonbourgeois character of a slave society committed to export and import markets, see Eugene D. Genovese, The Political Economy of Slavery: Studies in the Economy and Society of the Slave South (New York, 1967), esp. p. 23; and Elizabeth Fox- Genovese, Within the Plantation Household: Black and White Women of the Old South (Chapel Hill, 1988), pp. 53-58. While I was completing the draft of my book there became available James A. Henretta, "The War for Independence and American Economic Development," in The Economy of Early America: The Revolutionary Period, iy6y,-iyyo, ed. Ronald Hoffman, etal. (Charlottesville, Va., 1988), pp. 45-87, which stresses the noncapitalist development of American production between the Revolution and 1815.

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### Shortened citation:

Clark, *The Roots of Rural Capitalism*, 14-15.

CHAPTER 8 · SECONDARY SOURCE S8.02

# The Market Revolution in America: Social, Political, and Religious Expressions, 1800–1880

Melvyn Stokes and Stephen Conway, eds.

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|---|---|
| WORK | The Market Revolution in America: Social, Political, and Religious Expressions, 1800–1880 |
| SELECTION | Introduction |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages 11-12 · University Press of Virginia, 1996. |

## Excerpt

One crucial difficulty was chronology. While Sellers's discussion of social and cultural changes ranges back to the eighteenth century, his narrative of political development opens with the final act of the War of 1812 and closes with the Wilmot Proviso. The transformation of a mainly subsistence society into a largely market-oriented one took considerably longer than this.[44] Robert Gross wrote about the tensions produced by commercial pressures in revolutionary Concord. Winifred Rothenberg has documented the emergence of a market economy in Massachusetts between 1785 and 1800. Joyce Appleby saw liberal capitalism as appealing strongly to farmers in the Middle Atlantic states in the 1790s, and the Jeffersonian victory of 1800 as the triumph of a new capitalist social order.[45]

At the other end of the timescale, as Joel H. Silbey points out, the market's conquest remained patchy in many areas long after 1850.[46]

## Author's Notes

44. Recent historians of agricultural society have perceived the term subsistence as misleading. It is explicitly rejected, for example, by Christopher Clark in his Roots of Rural Capitalism. Yet the word is still employed by many scholars, including Charles Sellers, and—if suitably qualified—retains a certain value as a kind of descriptive shorthand.

45. Robert Gross, The Minutemen and Their World (New York, 1976); Winifred Barr Rothenberg, From Market-Places to a Market Economy: The Transformation of Rural Massachusetts, 1750-1850 (Chicago, 1992); Joyce Appleby, Capitalism and a New Social Order: The Republican Vision of the 1790s (New York, 1984). Similar considerations are raised by Allan Kulikoff, The Agrarian Origins of American Capitalism (Charlottesville, Va., 1992), and James Henretta, "The War for Economic Independence and American Economic Development," in his The Origins of American Capitalism: Collected Essays (Boston, 1991).

46. Symposium, 458. It is notable, for example, that Taylor's "transportation revolution" lasted until 1860, Goodman's study of homestead exemption laws covered the period up to 1880, and Goodrich's analysis of government aid to internal communications ended in 1890. 47- John R. Commons, Myself (New York, 1934), p. 11; William Allen White, The Autobiography of William Allen White (New York, 1946), pp. 43, 66; Steven Hahn, The Roots of Southern Populism: Yeoman Farmers and the Transformation of the Georgia Upcountry, 1850-1890 (New York, 1983).

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Melvyn Stokes and Stephen Conway, eds., *The Market Revolution in America: Social, Political, and Religious Expressions, 1800–1880* (Charlottesville: University Press of Virginia, 1996), 11-12.

**Shortened citation:**

Stokes, *The Market Revolution in America*, 11-12.

CHAPTER 8 · SECONDARY SOURCE S8.03

# The Transportation Revolution, 1815–1860

George Rogers Taylor

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|---|---|
| WORK | The Transportation Revolution, 1815–1860 |
| SELECTION | Changing Costs of Transportation |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages 134 · Rinehart, 1951. |

## Excerpt

Actual charges for wagon carriage show wide variation even within given sections of the country. Thus, for three turnpikes leading out of Boston the situation was as follows: rates northward to Concord, New Hampshire, were 20 cents a ton-mile in 1822, westward to Worcester 17.5 cents in 1833, and southward to Fall River 7.5 cents in 1828.[8] A Pennsylvania estimate of 1824 gives the cost of turnpike transportation in that state as a little more than 13 cents a ton-mile. At the time when railroads were first introduced, 20 cents a ton-mile appears to have been regarded as the average wagon charge. By the fifties, 15 cents was considered the usual rate on 'ordinary highways.'[9]

On even the earliest railroads rates were appreciably lower than those charged for wagon transportation. When the railroad from Boston to Worcester began operation in 1833, its charge between the two terminals was 6.25 cents a ton-mile as compared to 17.5 cents on the turnpike.[10] As railroads improved and iron rails linked the chief commercial centers of the country, land transportation became so cheap as to permit long-distance shipment of bulky products.

## Author's Notes

8. Roberts, The Middlesex Canal, 1793-1860, p. 149; Taylor, "The Turnpike Era in New England, p. 319; Report of the Board of Commissioners of Internal Improvements in Relation to the Examination of Sundry Routes for a Railway from Boston to Providence (Boston: 1828), p. 49; Report of the Board of Commissioners for the Survey of One or More Routes for a Railway from Boston to Albany (Boston, 1828), pp. 49-52.

9. George L. Vose, Handbook of Railroad Construction: For the Use of American Engineers (Boston: James Monroe and Company, 1857), p. 3; Logan G. McPherson, Railroad Freight Rates in Relation to the Industry and Commerce of the United States (New York: Henry Holt and Company, 1909), pp. 148-149; MacGill, History of Transportation, p. 223, fn.; Hunt's Merchants' Magazine, V (September, 1841), 284; Andrews Report, p. 380; Ringwalt, Development of Transportation Systems in the United States, p. 28.

10. Taylor. "The Turnpike Era in New England," p. 319.

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Taylor, George Rogers. *The Transportation Revolution, 1815–1860*. Economic History of the United States 4. New York: Rinehart, 1951.

**Footnote citation:**

George Rogers Taylor, *The Transportation Revolution, 1815–1860* (Economic History of the United States 4. New York: Rinehart, 1951), 134.

**Shortened citation:**

Taylor, *The Transportation Revolution, 1815–1860*, 134.

CHAPTER 8 · SECONDARY SOURCE S8.04

# Commonwealth: A Study of the Role of Government in the American Economy: Massachusetts, 1774–1861

Oscar Handlin and Mary Flug Handlin

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|---|---|
| WORK | Commonwealth: A Study of the Role of Government in the American Economy: Massachusetts, 1774–1861 |
| SELECTION | Transportation |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages 184-185 · New York University Press, 1947. |

## Excerpt

To achieve their objectives, the merchants turned naturally to the state. An unfriendly national administration left little hope of federal aid, and individuals were slow to take the initiative or risk.[60] An unsuccessful petition requesting state subscription to the Gloucester Canal to Boston pointed out:

A few only of the most enterprizing citizens of Gloucester appear to be engaged in the work as proprietors, and as they are actively engaged in commerce, and prefer to employ their capital in commercial pursuits; they are desirous that the Commonwealth from the public utility of the project should bear a part of the cost.[61]

The most direct and powerful means of improvements seemed to rest in the Commonwealth. 'Many things,' it was acknowledged, 'should no doubt be left to individual enterprize,' but transportation 'may and ought to receive a salutary stimulus from well timed public encouragement.'[62]

General agreement about the need for government aid did not forestall tedious disagreement about its form, disagreement that delayed every positive step for more than a decade. Tentative attempts to meet the problem came early and accelerated after the Treaty of Ghent. Fears that the Connecticut River trade would drift to New York led to a demand in 1814 for a westward link. Two years later, the legislature appointed Loammi Baldwin and John Farrar to report on a canal to unite the Connecticut and Merrimack rivers. In 1818, Baldwin, drawing on his experience as engineer for Virginia, suggested that Massachusetts follow the example of that state in creating a board of public works, a mammoth public holding corporation, to gather information, plan, and invest in internal improvements.[63] The Empire State's Erie Canal quickened interest in his proposal for a canal from Boston to the Hudson. 'Enough has been executed in the State of New York,'wrote an influential contemporary, 'to convince the most sceptical, that Massachusetts must be intersected by canals, or the capital will suffer.'[64]

But the emergence of a new factor put off action. The feasibility of the Granite Railroad, chartered to carry stone to the Bunker Hill Monument, struck a deathblow at canal projects, particularly in Massachusetts, where mountains towered between Boston and the Hudson Valley.[65] T. H. Perkins' petition for a railroad to Albany and Governor Lincoln's warning that others were outdistancing the Bay State led to the appointment of a legislative committee and the review in the next few years of the various projects.[66]

Farmers, attracted by easier markets for their products, regarded the proposed road favorably at this time. In the west, local committees of correspondence organized to press vigorously for it.[67] The Blackstone Canal opening the interior business of. Massachusetts to Providence added a forceful point to their arguments. Meanwhile, the growing city of Worcester, until then a village of four thousand, demanded connection with the seaboard. Impressed by the urgency, a new Board of Directors of Internal Improvement, led by Nathan Hale, recommended a railroad via Worcester and Springfield to Albany, and warned that 'the assistance of the Government in some manner and to some extent... must be given to the work.'[68]

## Author's Notes

60. Cf., e.g., [W. Phillips], 'Statistical Annals,' North Amer. Rev., IX, 220 ff. For later demands for federal assistance, cf. Caldwell, 'Indirect Influences of Rail-Roads,' The N ew-England Mag., II, 292 ff.

61. M. A., Senate, 6882/1.

62. [J- Sparks], 'Internal Improvements of North Carolina,' North Amer. Rev., XII, 17. Cf. also, infra, pp. 186 ff.

63. Cf. Boston Gazette, Feb. 28, 1814; Boston Commercial Gazette, Jan. 25, 1816; Recorder, Jan. 24, 31, 1816; [L. Baldwin], 'Annual Report,' North Amer. Rev.,NIII, 3 ff.; cf. also, [J. L. Sullivan], 'Internal Improvements in South Carolina,' ibid., XIII, 144 ff. POLICY OF ACQUIESCENCE 185 York,'wrote an influential contemporary, 'to convince the most sceptical, that Massachusetts must be intersected by canals, or the capital will suffer.'64 But the emergence of a new factor put off action. The feasibility of the Granite Railroad, chartered to carry stone to the Bunker Hill Monument, struck a deathblow at canal projects, particularly in Massachusetts, where mountains towered between Boston and the Hudson Valley.65 T. H. Perkins' petition for a railroad to Albany and Governor Lincoln's warning that others were outdistancing the Bay State led to the appointment of a legislative committee and the review in the next few years of the various projects.66 Farmers, attracted by easier markets for their products, regarded the proposed road favorably at this time. In the west, local committees of correspondence organized to press vigorously for it.67 The Blackstone Canal opening the interior business of. Massachusetts to Providence added a forceful point to their arguments. Meanwhile, the growing city of Worcester, until then a village of four thousand, demanded connection with the seaboard. Impressed by the urgency, a new Board of Directors of Internal Improvement, led by Nathan Hale, recommended a railroad via Worcester and Springfield to Albany, and warned that 'the assistance of the Government in some manner and to some extent . . . must be given to the work.'68 Still, the form in which aid by the Commonwealth would best serve to modernize the communications system remained

64. Bowen s Boston Nezvs-Letter, Apr. 22, Dec. 16, 1826. Cf. also, North Amer. Rev., XIV, 231 ff., XXIV, 1 ff.; Holland, Western Mass., I, 412; 'Q,' Boston Commercial Gazette, Mar. 24, 1825.

65. North Amer. Rev., XXIV, 475 ff. For the granite railway, cf. Cary, Thomas Perkins, pp. 222 ff.

66. 'Message of Levi Lincoln,' Senate Docs., 1826-27, pp. 7-9; 'Speech of Levi Lincoln,' Senate Docs., 1826-27, pp. 5, 13 ff.; Winsor, Boston, IV, 116 ff.; Holland, Western Mass., I, 413; st. 1827, ch. 116.

67. Cf. the correspondence from Springfield, West Springfield, Westfield, and Otis, Aug. 6, 9, 11, 31, 1827, Sedgwick II Papers, VIII; Senate Docs., 1828-29, no. 2, pp. 9, 10; J. E. A. Smith, Pittsfield, to 1876, pp. 517 ff.; North Amer. Rev., XXVIII, 529.

68. Cf. st. 1822, ch. 27; st. 1823, ch. 77; st. 1825, ch. 144; st. 1826, ch. 74; Senate Docs., 1828-29, no. 24, pp. 1-4; North Amer. Rev., XXVIII, 528 ff.; Crane, 'Lumber Business of Worcester,' Colls, of Wore. Soc., I, 19; Holland, Western Mass., I, 414; Winsor, Boston, IV, 122 ff.

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**Shortened citation:**

Handlin, *Commonwealth*, 184-185.

CHAPTER 8 · SECONDARY SOURCE S8.05

# Enterprising Elite: The Boston Associates and the World They Made

Robert F. Dalzell Jr.

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|---|---|
| WORK | Enterprising Elite: The Boston Associates and the World They Made |
| SELECTION | Transportation, Banking, and Insurance |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages 82-83 · Harvard University Press, 1987. |

## Excerpt

By the time the Associates purchased their first railroad shares, a characteristic model of joint public and private action with regard to transportation had already evolved in Massachusetts. In that sense there was less room for innovation than in other sectors of the economy, but the model did allow individuals to vary the level of their participation: they could invest as much or as little as they chose. In the Associates' case a decision to hold investment in turnpikes and canals to a minimum preceded a much heavier—if still limited—commitment to railroads.

Broadly speaking, the commonwealth's approach to transportation projects left to private investors responsibility for taking both the initiative and the risks. In return, the government granted such investors, through charters of incorporation, certain valuable powers— typically the right to take land by eminent domain and permission to charge tolls. In some cases the powers extended farther and included monopoly privileges over specified routes or the right to operate lotteries to raise money. In the bargain it struck with private investors, the government also sacrificed much of the control it might have exercised over the expanding transportation network. Charters of incorporation did impose standards of quality in construction and usually set time limits within which projects had to be completed; upon occasion they even regulated tolls and profits. But exceptions were almost always granted if the original terms proved too confining. And as time passed the tendency was to require less in the first place, if only to save the trouble of negotiating new terms later.[5]

In all of this the state gave away a great deal in return for an uncertain and ill-defined promise of gain. Equally questionable was the fundamental equity of the policy. Instead of relying on private investors, the government could have developed the transportation network itself, covering the costs out of tax revenues. Such an approach would not have gone unopposed: memories of Shays' Rebellion—when an overly heavy burden of taxation had very nearly toppled the social order—ran deep in Massachusetts. Still, in electing not to finance transportation improvements through the tax system, the state was making a choice which, as Morton Horwitz has pointed out, "had major consequences for the distribution of wealth and power in... society."[6] Presumably the commonwealth's goal was to facilitate economic development in the interests of all of its citizens, yet its manner of doing so stood to benefit some citizens more substantially—and far more directly—than others.

Nevertheless in practice such issues often seemed secondary to the more tangible results of the state's policy. Thanks to scores of bridge, turnpike, and canal-building ventures, a growing portion of the population was linked to the expanding market economy. Though not all sections or regions benefited equally, most gained at least something. Nor did the investors whose capital financed the effort necessarily reap great rewards. Up to the beginning of the railroad era, profits were generally much lower than expected. Indeed from that standpoint the commonwealth—and beyond it the average citizen—appeared to fare rather well.

## Author's Notes

5. Handlin and Handlin, Commonwealth, pp. 108-110 and 114-120.

6. Morton J. Horwitz, The Transformation of American Law, 1780-1860 (Cambridge, Mass., 1981), p. xv. See also pp. 63-139. Among other things Horwitz takes issue with the Handlins—and other "consensus" historians who have done similar work—for failing to ask "in whose interest" the pattern of governmental action documented in their studies was forged. "To a surprisingly great extent, they treated all instances of state intervention as equally proving their point, as indeed such evidence would tend to do, given the qualitatively undifferentiated questions they tended to ask" (p. xiv).

## Chicago Citations

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**Shortened citation:**

Dalzell, *Enterprising Elite*, 82-83.

CHAPTER 8 · SECONDARY SOURCE S8.06

# Government Promotion of American Canals and Railroads, 1800–1890

Carter Goodrich

| | |
|---|---|
| WORK | Government Promotion of American Canals and Railroads, 1800–1890 |
| SELECTION | Public Promotion |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages 268-269 · Columbia University Press, 1960. |

## Excerpt

In the period before the Civil War, the state governments committed some $300,000,000 in cash or credit to internal improvements, and local governments more than $125,000,000. Well over half of this amount was spent, as Chapter I I has shown, in the seven states directly confronting the Appalachian Barrier. By contrast, the federal government spent on internal improvements a sum less than one percent of this total during the Era of National Projects which ended with the Maysville Road veto. Even adding the costs of completing the National Road after 1830, the direct financial expenditure of the central government on early internal improvements was only about $7,000,000, though account should also be taken of its contributions to the development of transportation through the technical assistance rendered by the Army Engineers and through improvements not intended to produce revenue, such as military roads and river and harbor improvements. On the other hand, the federal government made much larger sums available to the states for their own internal improvements programs, by payments of a part of the proceeds of public land sold within their borders and through distribution of the federal surplus revenue, which a number of states applied to improvement purposes. There were also substantial gifts of land to the states to be used at their discretion for the same purpose.

## Chicago Citations

**Bibliography entry:**

Goodrich, Carter. *Government Promotion of American Canals and Railroads, 1800–1890*. New York: Columbia University Press, 1960.

**Footnote citation:**

Carter Goodrich, *Government Promotion of American Canals and Railroads, 1800–1890* (New York: Columbia University Press, 1960), 268-269.

**Shortened citation:**

Goodrich, *Government Promotion of American Canals and Railroads, 1800–1890*, 268-269.

CHAPTER 8 · SECONDARY SOURCE S8.07

# Aspirations and Anxieties: New England Workers and the Mechanized Factory System, 1815-1850

David A. Zonderman

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|---|---|
| WORK | Aspirations and Anxieties: New England Workers and the Mechanized Factory System, 1815-1850 |
| SELECTION | Excerpt from the supplied edition |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages 270-271 · Oxford University Press, 1992. |

## Excerpt

Some operatives did admit that the public image of the completely unselfish laborer was not an entirely accurate picture. Workers did have personal reasons for working in factories, but they were often phrased in very modest terms. An operative from Waltham, Massachusetts, explained that many mill girls came from all over New England to earn money for something more than the bare essentials, not to rescue their families from destitution. "There may be several daughters in one family, and each is desirous of promoting the general welfare; and, though they may have all the necessities of life, yet they desire more of its comforts and conveniences than they have the means of procuring at home."[22]

Many women clung tightly to their factory jobs, not because they had to support their families: quite to the contrary, because they saw their work as the foundation of their personal freedom. Beneath their proclamations of sacrifice and the ethic of hard work, they believed that industrial labor afforded them an independent living. "Song of the Spinners" reassured workers: "Despite of toil we all agree, / Or out of the mills, or in, / Dependent on others we ne'er will be, / So long as we're able to spin." Elizabeth Turner, even as she was praising the generosity of those who worked to help others, also recognized that many operatives felt "a spirit of honest independence, as they... realize that they can support themselves by their own efforts." Factory work was liberating women from the myths of female inferiority and dependence; female operatives were fulfilling their needs and rights to women's independence. When these women argued that their work and their wages were the foundation of their independence, they were not saying that they necessarily had to labor for their very survival; but neither were they dismissing their own efforts as mere diversion for pin money.[23]

Lucy Larcom saw how the spirit of independence in female factory workers gave them a sense of their own potential they had never known before. "It was like a young man's pleasure in entering upon business for himself. Girls had never tried that experiment before and they liked it. It brought out in them a dominant strength of character which the world did not previously see, but now fully acknowledges. Of course they had a right to continue at that freer kind of work as long as they chose...." The editors of the Operatives'Magazine, veterans of the Lowell mills, saw factory workers as the epitome of the honorable producer who made all of America independent. They wrote: "we have not with some, been accustomed to look upon the Operatives of our country as a low degraded class; but as those who, by their industry, energy, and enterprizes, are the producers of all that is around, which render us more independent and happier, than the other nations of the earth; and, hence, the most honorable class, and those of us who are of the greatest benefit to the world." Working women were encouraged to have pride in their being independent workers and respectable women.[24]

Many women workers believed in their independence because they earned their own cash wages and managed their own finances. They were still subject to the authority of their male managers, but they were not living in the family household, where their work was likely to be owned, in a sense, by their fathers or husbands. They were responsible for their own standard of living much more than they were contributing to their family's daily welfare. These women

did not seem to recognize that their two models—the selfless female worker and the independent female worker, each eagerly embracing factory labor—might come into conflict with each other. After all, if women were laboring for others, how could they say that their work was a crucial step toward their independence? Or if women wanted to live and work for themselves, how long would they remain a key component of the family economy? Tensions arose when women tried to retain genteel notions of femininity, propriety, sacrifice, and refinement, while also defining new realms of women's self-reliance, respect, intelligence, and dignity in the workplace. Yet, many operatives argued that the more women worked in the factories, the more successful they were in uniting their high moral standards with their newfound autonomy. Nearly every worker agreed that they started out from their country homes with strong ethical constitutions—but the question remained as to whether the factory system complemented or compromised those moral principles. Lucy Larcom saw the mill girls rising above any possible detrimental effects of factory labor and preserving their rural inheritance of honesty and hard work. "Their vigor of character was a natural development. The New Hampshire girls who came to Lowell were descendents of the sturdy backwoodsmen who settled that State.... They were earnest and capable; ready to undertake anything that was worth doing. My dreamy, indolent nature was shamed into activity among them." Larcom knew that industrial labor was not always inspiring; it could sometimes be quite confining, but it did not necessarily jeopardize the high standards bred into most operatives. She concluded that "the girls who toiled together at Lowell... practically said, by numbering themselves among factory girls, that in our country no real odium can be attached to any honest toil that any self-respecting woman might undertake."[25]

## Author's Notes

22. Letter of a Waltham, [Mass.], operative, in Farley, Operatives'Reply, pp. 11-13.

23. Lowell Offering, v. 1, April 1841, p. 32; Lowell Offering, v. 1, May 1841, p. 50.

24. Larcom, Girlhood, pp. 199-200; Operatives'Magazine, July 1841, p. 64.

25. Larcom, Girlhood, p. 196.

## Chicago Citations

### Bibliography entry:

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### Footnote citation:

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### Shortened citation:

Zonderman, *Aspirations and Anxieties*, 270-271.

CHAPTER 8 · SECONDARY SOURCE S8.08

# Aspirations and Anxieties: New England Workers and the Mechanized Factory System, 1815-1850

David A. Zonderman

| | |
|---|---|
| WORK | Aspirations and Anxieties: New England Workers and the Mechanized Factory System, 1815-1850 |
| SELECTION | Excerpt from the supplied edition |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages 206-207 · Oxford University Press, 1992. |

## Excerpt

Two years later, some spinners at the Dwight Corporation in Chicopee refused to tend their machines when they were started one Monday morning, because of a reported wage reduction. They remained off the job until Tuesday afternoon, when management persuaded them to return for a fifty-cent per week raise. This walkout was very limited in scope, without any accompanying public displays. But these women maintained their ranks, and the managers quickly realized that even a small turn-out could adversely affect their company, so they settled the matter. Why this modest turn-out succeeded where larger protests failed is not certain. Perhaps the Dwight Corporation was caught at a vulnerable moment in its production schedule and needed those spinners at work no matter what the cost.[25]

Most of the strikes in the mechanized factories of antebellum New England, from the early 1820s to the mid-1840s, confirmed the patterns set by the first walkout at Waltham. Most strikes took place at large textile mills; they were often led by women (frequently weavers); and they usually revolved around a dispute over wages. There are many possible explanations for this basic pattern of protest. First, the predominance of strikes in textile mills may be a historical artifact. Protests at large mills usually involved a substantial number of workers, and women often spoke out publicly for the first time at these turn-outs. These strikes were therefore bound to attract attention because of their unusual character. It is possible that other protests occurred at smaller, more isolated factories, but no one bothered to record these walkouts for posterity. Rural factory villages may also have been particularly unconducive to organizing labor protests because there were fewer workers to draw on, fewer public meeting places to congregate at, and more power concentrated in the hands of the owners. The large textile mills, on the other hand, brought together unprecedented numbers of workers in a single factory complex. Many of these operatives, especially the women, were living and working away from home for the first time. As a community of female operatives formed, with its own moral standards and its own forms of peer pressure, that emerging network could have been a powerful source of protest and resistance. The workers who participated in strikes were reappropriating the sense of discipline and interdependence they learned in the mills and using those principles to organize themselves in united protest. Weavers were often particularly known for their willingness to assist each other on the job, and perhaps on strike as well. Weavers also had more skill and earned higher wages than many other operatives—hence, they had higher working status and more economic resources. These weavers may have thought, therefore, that they had more to fight for, and more to fight with, than their co-workers.[26]

In some mills, women ran the entire strike when their male co-workers failed to offer much assistance. Male operatives, often paid on a daily basis, were usually less affected by the wage cuts, which were based on piece rate reductions. Managers may have deliberately aimed at women's piece rates because such cuts produced the most savings and seemed to divide the work force along gender lines. But manufacturers who assumed that women would accept these cuts more readily than men were often gravely mistaken. Female operatives showed clearly that, in many cases, they were ready and willing to organize in defense of their rights. They were saying that if men would not ally with them—whether out of fear of economic competition or social stereotypes about the supposedly weaker sex—then the women would help themselves.[27]

## Author's Notes

25. Voice of Industry, November 21, 1845.

26. Kulik et al. (1982), p. 481; Dublin, Women at Work, pp. 85, 103-104.

27. Shlakman (1934-1935), pp. 122-123.

## Chicago Citations

**Bibliography entry:**

Zonderman, David A. *Aspirations and Anxieties: New England Workers and the Mechanized Factory System, 1815-1850*. New York: Oxford University Press, 1992.

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David A. Zonderman, *Aspirations and Anxieties: New England Workers and the Mechanized Factory System, 1815-1850* (New York: Oxford University Press, 1992), 206-207.

**Shortened citation:**

Zonderman, *Aspirations and Anxieties*, 206-207.

CHAPTER 8 · SECONDARY SOURCE S8.09

# Rockdale: The Growth of an American Village in the Early Industrial Revolution

Anthony F. C. Wallace

| | |
|---|---|
| WORK | Rockdale: The Growth of an American Village in the Early Industrial Revolution |
| SELECTION | Work Rules in Cotton Factories |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages 326-328 · Alfred A. Knopf, 1978. |

## Excerpt

A curious customary mixture of moralities in the factories was developing, with some management actions and attitudes clearly aiming at the moral improvement of workers and others indicating indifference. These mixed messages pertained to the presence—and sometimes the absence—of work rules.

Beyond those rules of thumb that operatives had to learn and practice in order to run the machines efficiently and safely, every factory had a set of rules of a more general kind, some of them vaguely moral and some explicitly so. Sometimes these rules were printed; often, printed or in long hand, they were posted in the factories; frequently (although not at Riddle's mill) new hands were required to sign them.i Violation of these rules was enforced by a system of punishments.[1]

Some of the rules were safety regulations of an obviously necessary kind. At Parkmount—and no doubt in every establishment in the industry —there was a fixed rule against smoking inside the mill. Oil and cotton dust were all about; in some places they made an explosive mixture, which could be ignited by sparks from a pipe or cigar. Violation of this rule was grounds for discharge. Fighting in the mill could also lead to discharge, for it could result in lost time, inattention, and damage to machinery and goods. Coming to work drunk would be grounds for dismissal.[2]

Other rules dealt with the organization of work. Punctuality had a peculiar importance in these early mills, far beyond what has become customary in later times when each machine is moved by its own electric motor, and this importance had nothing really to do with the Protestant ethic (although that ethic could be used to rationalize it). As we showed earlier, in mills of this era, whether powered by water or steam, each machine in the plant was driven by a belt attached to a line shaft running off the main shaft which was connected to the water wheel. Once the main shaft was connected to the prime mover, every shaft and every belt in the building began to turn. Although each machine could be disconnected from the shafting by moving a hand clutch, which shifted the belt to the loose pulley, the entire factory was designed mechanically to run under a full load of machinery. Furthermore, at the big mules and carding engines, where several people were required to service one machine, the absence of one little boy or girl piecer might immobilize not only the machine but also the mule spinner and another helper. And, since the machines were designed to run in line, so that cotton was moving continuously through the plant from one machine to another, the absence of workers to tend any machine could stop the entire factory by interrupting the supply of materials at one point and piling up excessive quantities at the next.

Rules about punctuality therefore were rigid. Tardiness was punished by docking wages or, if repeated, by dismissal—even in the case of the small children. Working conditions in the mills of two of the Chester Creek manufacturers were described in the 1837 Pennsylvania Senate investigation, and the witnesses (including Riddle and Crozer and William Shaw, one of their past employees) all agreed on the severity of the punctuality requirements. William Shaw, who worked two years for the Riddles and then for Crozer, reported:

I have known work to commence as early as twenty minutes past four o'clock, in the summer season, and to work as late as half an hour before eight, P.M.; an hour and a-half allowed for breakfast and dinner, when the hands all leave to go to dinner—children and all; the ringing of the bell was the notice to begin, and docking wages the penalty; the

foreman rings the bell and stops the machinery. In the cities, the engineer rings the bell and stops the machinery.

The period of labor is not uniform; in some cases, from sun to sun. It is most common to work as long as they can see; in the winter they work until eight o'clock, receiving an hour and a-half for meals; an hour and a-half is the entire time allowed for going, eating and returning; and that time is often shortened by the ringing of the bell too soon.

Punishment, by whipping, is frequent; they are sometimes sent home and docked for not attending punctually; never knew both punishments to be inflicted; generally the children are attentive, and punishments are not frequent.

Riddle felt that the factory regimen in Northern Ireland, when he worked there as a youth, was more strict than in the Chester Creek factories: "Children suffered very much under that system. They got to adhere to their regular hours, pretty much. The time was still severe on them. There was a great deal of whipping there, we have not here." And Crozer noted that the children, if they were to be employed at all, had to work under the same discipline as adults: "... the work of children cannot be shortened, without also abridging that of adults, as the labor of one is connected with that of the other, being part of a system, which, if broken in upon, destroys a connecting link in the chain of operations.[3]

A related work rule mentioned by the Chester Creek witnesses was that children should be constantly attentive and not sleep in the mill (even if not at the moment actively employed). Violations of such rules were punished in a variety of ways: notifying the parent, sending home. docking wages, pulling ears, slapping, whipping, and outright dismissal.

## Author's Notes

1. Pa. Senate Journal, 1837-38, Part 2, pp. 280, 302.

2. DCHS, Parkmount Day Book, passim.

3. Pa. Senate Journal, 1837-38, Part 2, pp. 280, 300, 304.

## Chicago Citations

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### Footnote citation:

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### Shortened citation:

Wallace, *Rockdale*, 326-328.

CHAPTER 8 · SECONDARY SOURCE S8.10

# Working People of Philadelphia, 1800–1850

Bruce Laurie

| | |
|---|---|
| WORK | Working People of Philadelphia, 1800–1850 |
| SELECTION | Working-class Cultures, 1820-1837 |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages 90-92 · Temple University Press, 1980. |

## Excerpt

The event referred to in these lyrics, the strike for a ten-hour day, offers the best evidence of the depth of worker unrest. It began inauspiciously in late May of 1835, when the coal heavers on the Schuylkill docks left their jobs in protest against long hours. Parading through the city on June 3, they caught the eye of cordwainers peering through workshop windows. The cordwainers threw down their awls and rushed to join the procession, shouting "We are all day laborers!"[18] The mushrooming line of march attracted carpenters and other tradesmen in quick succession and precipitated spontaneous rallies of artisans throughout the city. Smiths, leather dressers, plumbers, painters, and cigar makers among others voted to stand out by the end of the week. The republic's first general strike was on; and general it was. The fervor reached into textile mills around the county and into the homes of outworkers, who normally had no interest in the hours question. But rate cuts forced the cottagers to work longer and faster. The only form their struggle for shorter hours could take was a wage increase, and they struck for rate advances. A festive air prevailed. There were great parades and rallies uniting workers with master craftsmen and other middle class sympathizers all bearing banners with variations of the motto "6 to 6."[19] Friendly shopkeepers displayed this battle cry in windows and youngsters chalked it on fences.[20] Wage earners were seen everywhere except at their workplaces, which moved the *United States Gazette* to note the obvious: "Our buildings are at a stand, and business generally is . . . impeded."[21]

No one knows how many workers walked off their jobs or won their point through negotiation. On June 10, after some mechanics celebrated victory and others prepared to stand out one newspaper counted twenty trades still on strike.[22] At least double that number—possibly as many as 20,000 workers—participated in walkouts, and all were successful, though the millhands compromised on an eleven-hour day and some trades waited until the fall and following spring before announcing a ten-hour day.[23] The laborers who had sparked the strike were among the most triumphant of all. Those toiling on public projects in Southwark extracted a wage increase as well as an ordinance making ten hours a legal day's work.[24]

Irish hand loom weaver John Ferral correctly pronounced the general strike an unexpected boon to the General Trades' Union.[25] Membership, he happily observed, soared in the wake of the stand-out, as ad hoc strike committees created in the fervor of the moment turned into unions, and established societies inducted scores of journeymen. The inflow of new recruits, most of whom were strangers to trade unionism, transformed the G.T.U. from a small clique of radicals into a diversified union representing workers of various cultures.

Though declining working conditions pitted traditionalist and revivalist workers against employers, and propelled them into the Trades' Union, neither these conditions nor the euphoria of the general strike alone shaped the G.T.U. or sustained class unity. Such solidarity, in the 1830s, as in any period, could not be sustained without the cultivation of talented leadership.

## Author's Notes

18. Ferguson, Organizing to Beat the Devil, p. 357.

19. Minutes of the Philadelphia Conference of the Methodist Episcopal Church, 1833-1846 (Philadelphia; n.pub., n.d.), p. 27.

20. Minutes of the Philadelphia Conference of the Methodist Episcopal Church, Held at Philadelphia, March 30, 1836 (Philadelphia: James Harmsted, 1836), p.

21. John Allen Krout, Origins of Prohibition (New York: Alfred A. Knopf, 1925), pp. 112-13.

22. Ferguson, Organizing to Beat the Devil, p. 359.

23. Rev. J. Kennady, Sermon Delivered before the Sunday School Teachers' Union of the Methodist Episcopal Church of Philadelphia, September 29, 1839 (Philadelphia: Thomas U. Baker, 1839), p.

24. Rev. Fitch Reed, "The Influence of Moral Principle, Secured by Early Culture, Essential to National Prosperity," in Shipley W. Willson and Ebenezer Ireson, eds.. The Methodist Preacher: Or, Monthly Sermonsfrom Living Ministers (Boston: J. Putnam, 1 832), pp. 355-73. The quotation is on p. 367.

25. Compiled from Minutes of the General Assembly ofthe Presbyterian Church in the United States ofAmericafrom its Organization in A.D. 1798 to A.D. 1820 (Philadelphia: Presbyterian Board of PubHcation, 1847); Minutes of the General Assembly of the Presbyterian Church, 1821-1835, 1836-1841, 1842-1847, 1848-1849 (Philadelphia: By the Stated Clerk of the Assembly, n.d.); Minutes of the General Assembly of the Presbyterian Church in the United States of America (New School), 1838-1851 (New York: By the Stated Clerk of the Assembly, n.d.); Minutes Taken at 218 Notes the Several Annual Conferences of the Methodist Episcopal Church, 1810- 1820. 1821-1829 (Philadelphia: n.pub., n.d.); and Minutes of the Philadelphia Conference of the Methodist Episcopal Church, 1833-1846, 1847- 1864 (Philadelphia: n.pub., n.d.).

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**Bibliography entry:**

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**Shortened citation:**

Laurie, *Working People of Philadelphia, 1800–1850*, 90-92.

CHAPTER 8 · SECONDARY SOURCE S8.11

# A Shopkeeper's Millennium: Society and Revivals in Rochester, New York, 1815-1837

Paul E. Johnson

| | |
|---|---|
| WORK | A Shopkeeper's Millennium: Society and Revivals in Rochester, New York, 1815-1837 |
| SELECTION | Afterword |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages 138-139 · Hill and Wang, 1978. |

## Excerpt

This solves the first problem raised by Tocqueville's analysis, but it confronts us with a second: the tendency to deduce the origins of religion from its social functions. Tocqueville stated that religion was strong in America because it created order among free individuals. We have seen that revivals did indeed create order, but only along lines prescribed by an emerging industrial bourgeoisie. Here we enter dangerous territory. For if we infer the causes of revivals from their results, we must conclude that entrepreneurs consciously fabricated a religion that suited their economic and social needs.' That would demonstrate little more than our own incapacity to take religion seriously. True, Charles Finney's revival at Rochester helped to solve the problems of labor discipline and social control in a new manufacturing city. But it was a religious solution, addressed to religious problems. The revival will remain unexplained until we know how social problems became translated into specifically religious unrest.

The businessmen and masters in Charles Finney's audience had been born into New England villages in which the roles of husband, father, and employer were intertwined, and they had reconstructed that village order on the banks of the Genesee. In the early years, disorder and insubordination were held in check, for master and wage earner worked together and slept under the same roof. Fights between workmen were rare, and when they occurred masters witnessed the intelligible and personal stream of events that led up to them. Wage earners loafed or drank or broke the Sabbath only with the master's knowledge and tacit consent. When workers lived with proprietors or within sight of them, serious breaches of the peace or of accepted standards of labor discipline were uncommon. At the very least, workingmen were constrained to act like guests, and masters enforced order easily, in the course of ordinary social and economic transactions.

## Chicago Citations

**Bibliography entry:**

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**Shortened citation:**

Johnson, *A Shopkeeper's Millennium*, 138-139.

CHAPTER 8 · SECONDARY SOURCE S8.12

# The Wages of Whiteness: Race and the Making of the American Working Class

David R. Roediger

| | |
|---|---|
| WORK | The Wages of Whiteness: Race and the Making of the American Working Class |
| SELECTION | On Autobiography and Theory |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages 12-13 · Revised edition, Verso, 2007. |

## Excerpt

Thus, Du Bois's *Black Reconstruction* continually creates jarring, provocative theoretical images, mixing race and class by design. Black reconstruction is, for Du Bois, the key to the story of 'our [the US] labor movement'. The book is organized around the activities of workers, but those workers function, for Du Bois tragically, within racial categories: the first chapter is entitled 'The Black Worker' and the second 'The White Worker'. White labor does not just receive and resist racist ideas but embraces, adopts and, at times, murderously acts upon those ideas. The problem is not just that the white working class is at critical junctures manipulated into racism, but that it comes to think of itself and its interests as white.[23]

Du Bois regards the decision of workers to define themselves by their whiteness as understandable in terms of short-term advantages. In some times and places, he argues, such advantages showed up in pay packets, where the wages of white, native-born skilled workers were high, both compared with those of Blacks and by world standards.[24] But vital for the white workers Du Bois studied most closely was, as he puts it in a brilliant, indispensable formulation, that even when they 'received a low wage [they were] compensated in part by a . . . public and psychological wage.' Here Du Bois not only emphasizes status but the extent to which status was bound up with real social gains. He continues:

They were given public deference . . . because they were white. They were admitted freely, with all classes of white people, to public functions [and] public parks. . . . The police were drawn from their ranks and the courts, dependent on their votes, treated them with leniency. . . . Their votes selected public officials and while this had small effect upon the economic situation, it had great effect upon their personal treatment. . . . White schoolhouses were the best in the community, and conspicuously placed, and cost anywhere from twice to ten times colored schools.[25]

As important as the specifics are here, still more important is the idea that the pleasures of whiteness could function as a 'wage' for white workers. That is, status and privileges conferred by race could be used to make up for alienating and exploitative class relationships, North and South. White workers could, and did, define and accept their class positions by fashioning identities as 'not slaves' and as 'not Blacks'.

When they did so, Du Bois argued, the wages of whiteness often turned out to be spurious. America's 'Supreme Adventure . . . for that human freedom which would release the human spirit from lower lust for mere meat, and set it free to dream and sing' gave way to a racism that caused 'capitalism [to be] adopted, forwarded and approved by white labor' and that 'ruined democracy'. Race feeling and the benefits conferred by whiteness made white Southern workers forget their 'practically identical interests' with the Black poor and accept stunted lives for themselves and for those more oppressed than themselves.[26]

Du Bois argued that white supremacy undermined not just working-class unity but the very *vision* of many white workers. He connected racism among whites with a disdain for hard work itself, a seeking of satisfaction off the job and a desire to evade rather than confront exploitation. Du Bois held that this would have been a better and more class-conscious nation and world had the heritage of slavery and racism not led the working class to prize whiteness.[27] Although these are positions that some neo-Marxists and post-Marxists have criticized as essentialist,

they nonetheless seem to me a model that takes us a long step toward seeing the whiteness of the white worker in the broad context of class formation rather than in the narrow confines of job competition.[28] Likewise, the tone here strives to emulate that of *Black Reconstruction*, and thus to be more tragic than angry.

## Author's Notes

23. W.E.B. Du Bois, *Black Reconstruction in the United States, 1860–1880* (New York, 1977 [1935]), 727 and passim.

24. Ibid., 30 and 633–34.

25. Ibid., 700–701.

26. Ibid., 30 and 700.

27. Du Bois, *Black Reconstruction*, 27–30, 347, 633–34, and 700–701. See also Du Bois, 'Dives, Mob and Scab, Limited,' *Crisis* 19 (March 1920): 235–36.

28. Sean Wilentz, 'Against Exceptionalism: Class Consciousness and the American Labor Movement,' *International Labor and Working Class History* 26 (Fall 1984): esp. 2–3. See also Norman Geras, 'Ex-Marxism Without Substance: Being a Reply to Laclau and Mouffe,' *New Left Review* 169 (May–June 1988): 43–46; and Cornel West, 'Rethinking Marxism,' *Monthly Review* 38 (February 1987) for some good sense on essentialism.

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Roediger, *The Wages of Whiteness*, 12-13.

CHAPTER 8 · SECONDARY SOURCE S8.13

# The Philadelphia Riots of 1844: A Study of Ethnic Conflict

Michael Feldberg

| | |
|---|---|
| WORK | The Philadelphia Riots of 1844: A Study of Ethnic Conflict |
| SELECTION | The Nativists |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages 41-42 · Greenwood Press, 1975. |

## Excerpt

Until recently, most historians assumed that the efflorescence of nativism in the 1840s represented little more than another outburst of anti-Catholic prejudice historically endemic in the great mass of American Protestants. This narrowly religious interpretation of nativism in the 1840s was first propounded by several Catholic scholars, but given its most widely read and accepted formulation in Ray Allen Billington's Protestant Crusade: A Study of the Origins of American Nativism.[1] After reviewing the reams of anti-Catholic literature generated by Protestant writers and lecturers in the 1840s, Billington concluded that the rise of nativism "could never have occurred had not the American people been so steeped in antipapal prejudice." Their hatred of Roman Catholicism "had been well grounded before the first English settlement and was fostered by the events of the entire colonial period." In order to explain why nativism flourished in the 1840s in particular, Billington had to concede that the arrival of Irish and German immigrants, rather than religious hatred in itself, rekindled the old fires of intolerance. The newcomers, he noted, were resented for a number of reasons: their poverty, their high crime rates, their poor sanitary habits, and their tendency to clannishness. Despite this social dimension to the anti-immigrant upsurge, however, Billington's analysis of nativist complaints against the new arrivals convinced him that the social arguments were simply rationalizations for the religious bigotry Protestant native Americans harbored in their hearts.

Fundamentally, the aliens were opposed because they were Catholics rather than because they were paupers or criminals. The preponderant number of papal adherents among the Irish and Germans coming to the United States made Americans wonder again if their land was safe from Popery and fears were current that this immigration was a means by which Romish power could be transferred to America.[2]

This religious interpretation of 1840s nativism reigned unchallenged until the 1950s, when a newly emergent interest in the social and psychological roots of prejudice stimulated historians to undertake a reevaluation of antebellum bigotry.[3] Billington and the Catholic scholars simply assumed the existence of religious prejudice and used the phenomenon itself to explain the behavior of Protestant nativists. The later studies of the nativist phenomenon have taken the analysis one step further, identifying the social characteristics of the nativists as a means for explaining the sources, rather than the symptoms, of their prejudice. Interestingly enough, the historians, sociologists, and psychologists who undertook these revisionist studies reached a conclusion similar to Billington's: that nativist complaints had little to do with the intrinsic character or behavior of the immigrants themselves. But these newer explanations of nativism go well beyond the simplistic one offered by the older religious interpretation. According to scholars such as Richard Hofstadter, David Brion Davis, and Seymour Martin Upset (for convenience they will be referred to here as the pluralist analysts of nativism),4 the immigrants served as a symbolic scapegoat onto which the nativists displaced their own social and psychological anxieties. The problem, as the pluralists saw it, was not to identify what it was about the immigrants—their Catholicism or their crime rates— that provoked the rise of nativism, but rather what it was that troubled the nativists themselves to cause them to respond so excessively to the presence of the immigrants.

Perhaps the most widely read analysis to come out of the new psychosocial history of American nativism was Richard Hofstadter's influential article describing "The Paranoid Style in American Politics." In Hofstadter's estimation, a

"paranoid style" rhetoric (as opposed to a clinically paranoid rhetoric) persistently creeps into American political discourse. Its users, while not necessarily "certifiable lunatics" in most cases, have tended to speak with "heated exaggeration, suspiciousness, and conspiratorial fantasy" to describe the world around them. Like true paranoiacs, persons who employ the paranoid style in their political discourse are subject to delusions of persecution and exalted visions of their own greatness. But a "vital difference" exists between the clinical paranoiac and the political variety: "The clinical paranoiac sees the hostile and conspiratorial world in which he feels himself to be living as directed specifically against him; whereas the spokesman of the paranoid style finds it directed against a nation, a culture, a way of life whose fate affects not only himself alone but millions of others."5

## Author's Notes

1. Ray Allen Billington, Protestant Crusade: A Study of the Origins of American Nativism (Chicago: Quadrangle, 1963).

2. Ibid., 1, 36.

3. This reawakening was sparked primarily by the work of sociologists Gordon W. Allport, particularly his Nature of Prejudice (Reading, Mass.: Addison-Wesley, 1954), and Theodor W. Adorno, et al., The Authoritarian Personality (New York: Harper and Bros., 1950).

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**Footnote citation:**

Michael Feldberg, *The Philadelphia Riots of 1844: A Study of Ethnic Conflict* (Westport, CT: Greenwood Press, 1975), 41-42.

**Shortened citation:**

Feldberg, *The Philadelphia Riots of 1844*, 41-42.

CHAPTER 8 · SECONDARY SOURCE S8.14

# The Know-Nothing Party in Massachusetts: The Rise and Fall of a People's Movement

John R. Mulkern

| | |
|---|---|
| WORK | The Know-Nothing Party in Massachusetts: The Rise and Fall of a People's Movement |
| SELECTION | Excerpt from the supplied edition |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages 14-15 · Northeastern University Press, 1990. |

## Excerpt

As soon as they disembarked, Irish immigrants stacked up in Boston or sought employment in the cities and growing mill towns in the Merrimack, Blackstone, and Connecticut valleys, where they “pigged” into ghetto tenements, shanties, and “Paddy Camplands.” Slum conditions and poverty made more difficult the transition that the newcomers had to make in their adopted country and led to the usual social aberrations of the uprooted and maladjusted. Approximately half the inmates in the state asylums, poorhouses, and prisons were foreigners. Most of the new arrivals, however, were self-supporting, taking whatever work was available. Generally, this meant domestic work or mill jobs for the women and unskilled, manual labor for the men. Paddy labor came cheap; Irish construction gangs, for example, built the railroads at 60 cents a day per man. They also dug the canals, laid the roads, and in the main provided the muscle for the kinds of dangerous, low-paying jobs that most American workers shunned.[26]

Textile manufacturers, in particular, welcomed the new arrivals as an endless source of cheap, tractable labor. By the early 1850s, half the workers in the mills of Lowell, Fall River, and Holyoke were foreigners, and by the end of the decade, half the textile work force in southern New England was Irish. As the Irish poured in, Yankee workers left in droves, their decision triggered not so much by an inability or unwillingness to compete for place—the native-born continued to monopolize the better jobs—as by the deteriorating conditions. The flood of foreign workers accelerated the erosion of working conditions, and management’s use of them as scabs no doubt stirred resentment; but in general, only the relatively few unskilled Yankee laborers and domestics had to compete directly with the newcomers for jobs. Other major industries, like boots and shoes and shipbuilding, employed few foreign workers. Lacking skills and connections in the building and maritime trades, the Irish remained mired at the bottom of the occupational strata at the close of the antebellum era.[27]

## Author's Notes

26. Laura E. Richards (ed.), Letters and Journals of Samuel Gridley Howe, 2 vols. (Boston, 1909), 2:280; Charles Francis Adams, Diary, April 10, 1856, Adams Family Papers, Massachusetts Historical Society (hereafter cited as MHS); DeBow, Compendium of the Seventh Census, 163-65; Warner, Census of Massachusetts, 1860, 335, 360-61; John P. Sanderson, Republican Landmarks—The Views and Opinions of American Statesmen on Foreign Immigration (Philadelphia, 1856), 204; Constance M. Green, Holyoke, Massachusetts: A Case Study of the Industrial Revolution in America (New Haven, 1939), 37-91; Arthur L. Eno, Jr. (ed.), Cotton Was King: A History of Lowell, Massachusetts (Lowell, Mass., 1976), 98-99; O. Handlin, Boston’s Immigrants, 54-87, 100, 117— 22, 250-53; Hart, Commonwealth History 4:157; Hoar, Autobiography 2:280—81; Worcester Palladium, June 28 and Aug. 30, 1854.

27. Persons, “Factory Legislation,” 56—58; C. Ware, Cotton Manufactures, 3, 11, 230-32; Green, Holyoke, 30-31; N. Ware, Industrial Worker, 117, 149-53; Eno, Cotton Was King, 94, 110-23; Siracusa, Mechanical People, 169, 174—75; Taylor, Transportation Revolution, 282-87, 292-300; Barnstable Patriot, March 27, 1855; O. Handlin, Boston’s Immigrants, 64, 70, 83, 253; Faler, “Cultural Aspects,” 374; Bean, “Party Transformation in Massachusetts,” 209.

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**Shortened citation:**

Mulkern, *The Know-Nothing Party in Massachusetts*, 14-15.

CHAPTER 8 · SECONDARY SOURCE S8.15

# The Know-Nothing Party in Massachusetts: The Rise and Fall of a People's Movement

John R. Mulkern

| | |
|---|---|
| WORK | The Know-Nothing Party in Massachusetts: The Rise and Fall of a People's Movement |
| SELECTION | Dark-Lantern Politics and the Know-Nothing Triumph |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages 83-85 · Northeastern University Press, 1990. |

## Excerpt

Political nativism on its own, in other words, fared poorly at the polls. The average antebellum voter may have shared some of the thinking of the hard-core bigots, but ordinarily he did not vote with them. Even when he did so in 1854, he had his own priorities. For example, nativism had little bearing on the Free-Soil decision to vote Know-Nothing in 1854 and none at all on the Free-Soil American conversion to Republicanism the following year. In the context of their overriding interest—to check the spread of slavery—nativism was of peripheral concern. Similarly, the Democratic party, plagued by the mass defection of its rank and file to "Sam" in 1854, polled a dismal 11 percent of the statewide total; but one year later, the Democratic vote had bounced back up to 26 percent of the total, which, given the interplay between the rigor of the American party's persecution of the Irish Catholic minority and the Democratic party's insistence on equal political and civil rights for immigrants and Roman Catholics, would be a study in inconsistency if nativism were the prime cause for their 1854 hiatus. The same may be said for the assertion that Democratic Coalitionists converted en masse to Know-Nothingism because of the defeat of the constitution, given the fact that the Know-Nothings implemented the Coalition's program. Like most voters, the Democrats had reasons other than bigotry or a desire to revive the Coalition for turning against the established parties and professional politicians. The Know-Nothing call to take part in the formation of a people's party and to use that party to address some of the more pressing problems affecting their daily lives struck a responsive chord with rank-and-file Democrats. After one: year of Know-Nothing rule, however, most Democrats had returned to their own party, their populist enthusiasm for the order having been extinguished by the ability of cunning politicans like Governor Gardner, Congressman Banks, and Senator Wilson to manipulate it to their own ends.[84]

## Author's Notes

84. Holt, Political Crisis of the 1850s, 174; Holt, "Politics of Impatience,"

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**Shortened citation:**

Mulkern, *The Know-Nothing Party in Massachusetts*, 83-85.

CHAPTER 8 · SECONDARY SOURCE S8.16

# Empire of Cotton: A Global History

Sven Beckert

| | |
|---|---|
| WORK | Empire of Cotton: A Global History |
| SELECTION | Introduction |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages Introduction (unpaginated supplied PDF) · Alfred A. Knopf (pb. Vintage), 2014. |

## Excerpt

Many historians have called this the age of "merchant" or "mercantile" capitalism, but "war capitalism" better expresses its rawness and violence as well as its intimate connection to European imperial expansion. War capitalism, a particularly important but often unrecognized phase in the development of capitalism, unfolded in a constantly shifting set of places embedded within constantly changing relationships. In some parts of the world it lasted well into the nineteenth century.

When we think of capitalism, we think of wage workers, yet this prior phase of capitalism was based not on free labor but on slavery. We associate industrial capitalism with contracts and markets, but early capitalism was based as often as not on violence and bodily coercion. Modern capitalism privileges property rights, but this earlier moment was characterized just as much by massive expropriations as by secure ownership. Latter-day capitalism rests upon the rule of law and powerful institutions backed by the state, but capitalism's early phase, although ultimately requiring state power to create world-spanning empires, was frequently based on the unrestrained actions of private individuals—the domination of masters over slaves and of frontier capitalists over indigenous inhabitants. The cumulative result of this highly aggressive, outwardly oriented capitalism was that Europeans came to dominate the centuries-old worlds of cotton, merge them into a single empire centered in Manchester, and invent the global economy we take for granted today.

War capitalism, then, was the foundation from which evolved the more familiar industrial capitalism, a capitalism characterized by powerful states with enormous administrative, military, judicial, and infrastructural capacities. At first, industrial capitalism remained tightly linked to slavery and expropriated lands, but as its institutions—everything from wage labor to property rights—gained strength, they enabled a new and different form of integration of the labor, raw materials, markets, and capital in huge swaths of the world.[7] These new forms of integration drove the revolutions of capitalism into ever more corners of the world.

As the modern world came of age, cotton came to dominate world trade. Cotton factories towered above all other forms of European and North American manufacturing. Cotton growing dominated the U.S. economy throughout much of the nineteenth century. It was in cottons that new modes of manufacturing first came about. The factory itself was an invention of the cotton industry. So was the connection between slave agriculture in the Americas and manufacturing across Europe. Because for many decades cotton was the most important European industry, it was the source of huge profits that eventually fed into other segments of the European economy. Cotton also was the cradle of industrialization in virtually every other part of the world—the United States and Egypt, Mexico and Brazil, Japan and China. At the same time, Europe's domination of the world's cotton industry resulted in a wave of deindustrialization throughout much of the rest of the world, enabling a new and different kind of integration into the global economy.

## Author's Notes

7. There is a vibrant literature on slavery and capitalism, including Eric Williams, Capitalism and Slavery (New York: Russell & Russell, 1961); Rafael de Bivar Marquese, "As desventuras de um conceito: Capitalismo histórico e a historiogra□a sobre escravidão brasileira," Revista de Historia 169 (July/December 2013), 223–53; Philip McMichael, "Slavery in the Regime of Wage Labor: Beyond Paternalism in the U.S. Cotton Culture," Social Concept 6 (1991): 10–28; Barbara L. Solow and Stanley L. Engerman, British Capitalism and Caribbean Slavery: The Legacy of Eric Williams (New York: Cambridge University Press, 1987); Gavin Wright, The Political Economy of the Cotton South: Households, Markets, and Wealth in the Nineteenth Century (New York: Norton, 1978); Joseph E. Inikori, Africans and the Industrial Revolution in England: A Study in International Trade and Development (New York: Cambridge University Press, 2002); Dale Tomich, "The Second Slavery: Mass Slavery, World-Economy, and Comparative Microhistories," Review: A Journal of the Fernand Braudel Center 31, no. 3 (2008); Robin Blackburn, The American Crucible: Slavery, Emancipation and Human Rights (London: Verso, 2011).

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CHAPTER 8 · SECONDARY SOURCE S8.17

# Spreading the News: The American Postal System from Franklin to Morse

Richard R. John

| | |
|---|---|
| WORK | Spreading the News: The American Postal System from Franklin to Morse |
| SELECTION | The Postal System as an Agent of Change |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages 23-24 · Harvard University Press, 1995. |

## Excerpt

The remaining three chapters focus, respectively, on the challenge to postal policy posed by the Sabbatarians, who were opposed to the transmission of the mail on the Sabbath; the Jacksonians, who were hostile to the growing influence ofthe postmaster general in national politics; and the slaveholders, who were outraged by the determination of abolitionists to organize a mass mailing to transform public attitudes toward slavery. In each of these controversies, the postal system was far more than the arena within which the action was staged. Rather, in a variety ofsubtle and not-so-subtle ways, it shaped the public issues that these controversies raised and the social divisions that they spawned. And in the course of this complicated drama ofchallenge and response, the political persuasion that has come to be known as Jacksonian Democracy was born and, with it, some of the most enduring features of American public life.[85]

## Author's Notes

85. For a more extended discussion of scholarship on the history of communications in the United States, including Chandler's treatment of the postal system, see Richard R. John, "American Historians and the Concept of the Communications Revolution," in Lisa Bud-Frierman, ed., InformationAcumen: The Understanding and Use ofI(nowledge in Modern Business (London: Routledge, 1994), pp. 98-

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**Shortened citation:**

John, *Spreading the News*, 23-24.

CHAPTER 8 · SECONDARY SOURCE S8.18

# A House Dividing: Economic Development in Pennsylvania and Virginia before the Civil War

John Majewski

| | |
|---|---|
| WORK | A House Dividing: Economic Development in Pennsylvania and Virginia before the Civil War |
| SELECTION | The Transition from State to Urban Investment in Pennsylvania |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages 119-120 · Cambridge University Press, 2000. |

## Excerpt

The financial failures of Pennsylvania's canals created a series of financial emergencies that pushed Pennsylvania perilously close to bankruptcy. The Mainline's revenues were never enough to repay the interest on the loans that financed the improvement.[25] The costly lateral canals that became part of the Mainline's political package further undermined the state's shaky financial situation, as these projects rarely covered their operating and repair expenses. Pennsylvania's spending policy depended upon a fresh infusion of loans and credit, which became increasingly difficult to find in the aftermath of the Panic of 1837. Faced with a rapidly mounting debt, in 1842 the state government suspended payments to the state's creditors while halting construction on works in progress.[26] Although the state would not give up on its canal system for another 15 years, the financial woes of the Pennsylvania government led to a general retrenchment of state expenditures that left most new transportation projects to local governments and private investors. State investment resumed in 1846 and continued until 1858, with the legislature spending $6 million to finish some of the branch canals and repair the Mainline. Amounting to only $500,000 per year, these expenditures never approached the size of the large appropriations of the 1830s and early 1840s. The state also dramatically curtailed investment in turnpike, bridge, and railroad corporations, deciding to auction off its shares in these enterprises in 1843. State investment in Pennsylvania's railroad network was therefore relatively unimportant. As Table 5.1 shows, it never exceeded $700,000, a minuscule amount given that the capital stock of Pennsylvania's railroad network in 1860 was more than $82 million.[27]

In the absence of significant state investment, local governments—particularly those of Philadelphia and Pittsburgh—picked up the slack. Pennsylvania localities invested a total of $18 million in railroad companies, with the Philadelphia and Pittsburgh areas accounting for more than 85 percent of all local investment. The rest of local expenditures were spread out over a number of towns and counties attempting to build branch roads or local feeders.[28] That Philadelphia and Pittsburgh dominated municipal investment is not at all surprising. In 1850, Philadelphia and Allegheny Counties accounted for 25 percent of Pennsylvania's total population and more than 75 percent of the state's manufacturing output. Each city, disappointed with the canal system's inability to capture western trade, had wealthy and influential residents eager to invest in railroads that would extend markets for their new mills, foundries, and factories. The population and wealth of Philadelphia and Pittsburgh also created large tax bases that allowed the two cities (at least in theory) to pay back municipal debts necessary to fund large railroad investments.[29] Philadelphia had the additional advantage of serving as the state's banking headquarters, giving the city government easier access to capital markets and financial expertise. By the late 1840s Philadelphia and Pittsburgh no longer needed the rest of the state to finance a central trunk line.

Historians have often thought of urban expenditures as just another form of government investment,[30] but the advantages of municipal investment over state investment were pronounced. Although Pennsylvania municipalities made their fair share of mistakes in railroad investments, at least local governments did not have to bargain with remote rural areas, thereby dispensing with the costly logrolling associated with the fractious state legislature. Even the choice of a project's exact route was easier, as more attention could be paid to economic factors rather than satisfying political allies in the state legislature. The rapid and profitable expansion of the Pennsylvania Railroad reflected the advantages of urban investment. The PRR, chartered in

1846, received more than a third of all local investment when Philadelphia county purchased $5 million worth of shares and Allegheny county invested another $1 million. Completed in 1853 from Harrisburg to Pittsburgh, the Pennsylvania Railroad was the key link of an allrail route from Philadelphia to the Ohio River. Without the decisive investments from Pittsburgh and Philadelphia, the PRR would probably not have begun construction in 1853, much less finished its mainline.[31]

## Author's Notes

25. Calculated from Poor, *History of the Railroads and Canals*, p. 559.

26. Pennsylvania's financial woes are chronicled in Grinath, Wallis, and Sylla, 'Debt, Default, and Revenue Structure,' p. 8.

27. Hartz, *Economic Policy*, p. 87; Poor, *History of the Railroads and Canals*, p. 423.

28. Goodrich, *Government Promotion*, p. 71.

29. Philadelphia accounted for 15 percent of all assessed real and personal property in 1815; by 1845 that figure had risen to 28 percent. Lindstrom, *Economic Development*, p. 29.

30. See, for example, Goodrich, *Government Promotion*, which often groups state investment and municipal investment as 'government enterprise' without distinguishing the different characteristics of each.

31. Ward,/. Edgar Thompson, p. 75.

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Majewski, *A House Dividing*, 119-120.

CHAPTER 8 · SECONDARY SOURCE S8.19

# Economic Policy and Democratic Thought: Pennsylvania, 1776–1860

Louis Hartz

| | |
|---|---|
| WORK | Economic Policy and Democratic Thought: Pennsylvania, 1776–1860 |
| SELECTION | The Struggle over Liquidation |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages 101-102 · Harvard University Press, 1948. |

## Excerpt

During the early forties a movement got under way to sell the public works to private investors, and by 1859 not a single section of the system remained in the hands of the state. The emergence of the sale movement was directly related to the state's financial embarrassment which came to a head in the issuance of interest certificates in 1842. Under the spur of immediate need for funds the state turned to the possibility of works liquidation as it turned to the disposal of its mixed corporation holdings. Maladministration of the works system, moreover, helped to induce disillusionment with public management. As effective corporate enterprises began to appear in the transportation field, that maladministration began to take on greater significance. In an earlier chapter I pointed out that, mainly under the impact of the sectional drive for commercial aggrandizement, railroads were chartered which competed deleteriously with the public works. In 1841 the state treasurer listed this competition as one of the principal causes of the financial crisis. A significant aspect of the relation between the new corporations and the public administration is revealed in the fact that many of them derived personnel from men who had originally gained experience on the state system. President Thomson of the Pennsylvania Railroad Company had previously served as an engineer on the Philadelphia and Columbia line of the works.[131] In 1854 Governor Bigler bitterly remarked that the public system had become "a species of Normal schools for the education of engineers and supervisors to take charge of other improvements."[132] The state could not compete with the drive of the emergent railroad capitalists.

Economically the works were a failure. Even had the system been well administered, technological change would have made it obsolescent; a canal-rail system could not survive in a railroad age. "It was an amphibious connexion of land and water," wrote Job Tyson to a London friend concerning the works in 1852, "happily elucidating the defects peculiar to both modes of transit, with the advantages of neither."[133] The Pennsylvania system could not even compete successfully with the Erie Canal. The route from the Ohio to Philadelphia was, it is true, over two hundred miles shorter than the route to New York provided by the Erie. But the Main Line, stretching over the Alleghenies and involving changes from canal to rail shipment,[134] made the Pennsylvania route less effective and more expensive.[135] A writer in Hunt's Merchants' Magazine, surveying the situation, concluded that Philadelphia must give up its dream of commercial greatness and concentrate upon industrial development instead.[136]

## Author's Notes

131. Sipes, *Pennsylvania Railroad*, p. 11. See also Scharf and Westcott, *History of Philadelphia*, III, 2199.

132. *Pa. Archives*, 4th, VII, 643.

133. *Commerce of Philadelphia*, p. 13.

134. Cf. Bishop, 'State Works,' pp. 245 ff.

135. *Hunt's Merchants' Magazine*, XIV (1846), 192. In their report of 1842 the canal commissioners recognized that the high rate of tolls in Pennsylvania was preventing her from competing successfully for the western trade. *House Journal*, 1842, III, 42. See also *Niles' Register*, Nov. 15, 1845; Bishop, 'State Works,' pp. 246–48.

136. 'That Pennsylvania and Philadelphia have not derived nearly so great a benefit in their trade with the west, from the construction of these internal improvements, as has accrued to the state and city of New York, we apprehend no one will doubt; nor, unless the cost

of transportation on the Pennsylvania works can be put at an equally low rate with that on those of the neighboring states, can it be doubted that Philadelphia must take her rank among the great manufacturing, rather than commercial cities of the Union.' *Hunt's Merchants' Magazine*, X (1844), 320.

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CHAPTER 8 · SECONDARY SOURCE S8.20

# A House Dividing: Economic Development in Pennsylvania and Virginia before the Civil War

John Majewski

| | |
|---|---|
| WORK | A House Dividing: Economic Development in Pennsylvania and Virginia before the Civil War |
| SELECTION | Railroads and Local Development |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages 63-64 · Cambridge University Press, 2000. |

## Excerpt

The Virginia Central needed the enthusiasm of Albemarle residents, for almost all of its private capital would come from local investors. Of the 215 names linked from the 1847 list of stockholders to the 1850 census, 84 percent lived in either Albemarle or Augusta county.[15] (Since the Virginia Central quickly extended the railroad to Augusta once it finished the Albemarle section, Augusta residents could expect significant indirect benefits.) Even within Albemarle, investment was extremely localized. Almost 90 percent of the Albemarle investors linked to the county's property tax records owned property within 5 miles of the road, with half of them living in or near Charlottesville. The merchants and planters living in the rich plantation district near Scottsville hardly put a dollar in the Virginia Central. Their lack of investment made sense. Why help finance a railroad that would divert trade away from their town?

The local residents who invested in the Virginia Central represented the growing diversity of the Albemarle economy. The influence of Albemarle's wealthiest planters had hardly disappeared. Men such as Thomas Jefferson Randolph, Alexander Rives, and William C. Rives were among the county's largest slaveholders and the company's largest shareholders. The large number of merchants, professionals, and artisans who invested in the enterprise, however, distinguished the railroad from the county's earlier developmental corporations (Table 3.1). Whereas wealthy slaveholders had contributed 50 or even 80 percent of the capital for Albemarle's early corporations, they provided only 24 percent of the railroad's capital. The greater diversity of investors demonstrated that "nothing succeeds like success" when it came to economic development. The earlier improvement of the Rivanna and James Rivers led Charlottesville to grow more populous and more wealthy, thereby creating a new set of potential investors to help fund more ambitious projects. The same interactive dynamic, as will be demonstrated in later chapters, worked on a far larger scale in Pennsylvania. Shares of Stock Owned (percent of sample) Average

## Author's Notes

15. Please see the appendix for an overview of precise methods used to link stockholders to census records.

## Chicago Citations

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CHAPTER 8 · SECONDARY SOURCE S8.21

# A Government Out of Sight: The Mystery of National Authority in Nineteenth-Century America

Brian Balogh

| | |
|---|---|
| WORK | A Government Out of Sight: The Mystery of National Authority in Nineteenth-Century America |
| SELECTION | Excerpt from the supplied edition |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages 154-155 · Cambridge University Press, 2009. |

## Excerpt

Yet, the federal government ruled most effectively precisely when it was least visible. If this was the case, what better place to deploy its substantial powers than at the borders of the nation, beyond those borders in the territories, and through international relations? Early nineteenth-century governance inverted the traditional locus of power. The territories, not the capital, were the repository of national authority.

It was outside the boundaries of conventional domestic politics that the General Government acted most powerfully. It was here that the General Government enjoyed plenary power. It did not have to share its authority with state and local government. It was here that citizens came into direct contact with the General Government, unmediated by federalism. In foreign policy, the General Government operated unilaterally, acquiring the Louisiana Territory or summarily clearing Indians from eastern lands. Even the most cursory examination of some of the supposedly marginal chores performed by the General Government at the edges of the nation suggests that what seems inconsequential to modern-day scholars was indeed vital to early nineteenth-century Americans.

## Chicago Citations

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**Shortened citation:**

Balogh, *A Government Out of Sight*, 154-155.

CHAPTER 8 · SECONDARY SOURCE S8.22

# Roads, Rails & Waterways: The Army Engineers and Early Transportation

Forest G. Hill

| | |
|---|---|
| WORK | Roads, Rails & Waterways: The Army Engineers and Early Transportation |
| SELECTION | Excerpt from the supplied edition |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages 222-223 · University of Oklahoma Press, 1957. |

## Excerpt

Although the army engineers had been brought into existence to build coastal defenses, their later construction activity lay primarily in the field of civil works. Their civil construction was extensive during the time of the General Survey Act but was greatest just before the Civil War.

The significant role which the army engineers achieved in the movement for internal improvements before the Civil War was indicative of the responsibility which the federal government took in this field. By the time of the War of 1812, it was widely agreed that the government would have to guide and assist public improvement, and the most effective instrumentality at its command was its skilled army engineers. A comprehensive system of planning and encouragement was thought to be necessary, and each President asked for a federal system of roads and canals and for increased support of the engineering branches of the War Department.

This assumption of governmental responsibility for the progress of transportation eventuated in passage of the General Survey Act of 1824. The Board of Engineers for Internal Improvements was instituted as the technical planning agency to execute this act. The board completed surveys and plans for many important projects, studying the military, commercial, and political benefits of each proposed improvement, but no federal program was adopted for securing their systematic completion. As it became evident that plans would not be fulfilled, generalized planning became pointless. After a few years, therefore, the planning function of the army engineers declined and atrophied. There was a slow change in emphasis from surveying for internal improvements to exploring the West and executing public works necessary for national expansion.

This instance of abortive planning is noteworthy. For two or three decades the planning of internal improvements was extensively advocated and debated. It is significant that this attempted planning was often felt to be essential, that it took place primarily on the engineering level, that it was designed to promote private enterprise and economic development, and that its abandonment was due more to political factors than to the opposition of private business.

## Chicago Citations

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**Footnote citation:**

Forest G. Hill, *Roads, Rails & Waterways: The Army Engineers and Early Transportation* (Norman: University of Oklahoma Press, 1957), 222-223.

**Shortened citation:**

Hill, *Roads, Rails & Waterways*, 222-223.

CHAPTER 8 · SECONDARY SOURCE S8.23

# Ten Hours' Labor: Religion, Reform, and Gender in Early New England

Teresa Anne Murphy

| | |
|---|---|
| WORK | Ten Hours' Labor: Religion, Reform, and Gender in Early New England |
| SELECTION | Labor Reform in the Thirties |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages 51-52 · Cornell University Press, 1992. |

## Excerpt

The presence of women in the larger regional movement presented several problems for the men. Women in New England were organizing over the issue of wages, while men were focusing, by and large, on time. This was not surprising, since the wage cuts in factory work, at least, had a gender bias: piece rates rather than day rates had been cut, and most men in factories were paid by the day.[41] The only male textile workers to feel these wage cuts were mule spinners in southern New England (who do not appear to have organized a protest over these cuts). But how should women organize? Should women organize themselves as men did? If so, how would issues of propriety be balanced against independence? Was the relationship between male and female workers economic or familial? Were women to present themselves as fellow wage earners or as sisters and daughters?

It was a tricky issue, because in many cases women were hired at lower wages than men as various trades were industrialized. But in the pages of The Artisan, at least, women received some support. “A.Z.," for example, was concerned that even skilled female workers, such as mantua makers and tailoresses, were still barely able to provide for themselves. Moreover, the writer claimed, women who did work formerly done by men were often found by their employers to be better workers “because their habits are more regular"—but they were never paid as much as men, though they suffered “more from acute disease than any others of the working class." Shoebinders and seamstresses were even worse off.[42]

Charles Douglass, as editor of The Artisan, echoed this view in presenting his support for the workingwomen of Baltimore who demanded higher wages in the fall of 1833: "If we have a pair of pantaloons well made, it is of no consequence to us whether the labor was bestowed upon them by male or female hands." The article also stressed, however, that women must take responsibility for organizing themselves and not depend on others.

Women are entitled to the same amount of wages as men, for the same quantum of services, and ought to receive it. But nothing will be done to improve their condition so long as they are careless and indifferent about it themselves."[43]

However, Douglass was not as sympathetic to the issue of female wages as these comments suggest. When the women in Lowell began to show a similar move toward collective organization a few months later, Douglass was quick to acknowledge them. In the middle of March 1834, soon after their strike had begun, he made an appearance at Jefferson Hall in Lowell, both to encourage the women in their organizing activities and to critique their goals. He urged them to make a shorter workday their first concern, arguing that their lengthy workdays were currently constructed "merely to satisfy the unjust and unreasonable demands of avaricious employers."[44] By ignoring the issue of wages, Douglass did not show much sensitivity to the plight of workingwomen or their demand for a wage level that, Thomas Dublin has pointed out, carried with it economic independence. Indeed, Douglass encompassed the female discourse of labor protest within that of the men, subordinating the issue of wages, which women had put forth, to the issue of time.

## Author's Notes

41. Dublin, Women at Work, p. 102. 52 Ten Hours' Labor others of the working class." Shoebinders and seamstresses were even worse off.42 Charles Douglass, as editor of The Artisan, echoed this view in presenting his support for the workingwomen of Baltimore who demanded higher wages in the fall of 1833: "If we have a pair of pantaloons well made, it is of no consequence to us whether the labor was bestowed upon them by male or female hands." The article also stressed, however, that women must take responsibility for organizing themselves and not depend on others. Women are entitled to the same amount of wages as men, for the same quantum of services, and ought to receive it. But nothing will be done to improve their condition so long as they are careless and indifferent about it themselves."43 However, Douglass was not as sympathetic to the issue of female wages as these comments suggest. When the women in Lowell began to show a similar move toward collective organization a few months later, Douglass was quick to acknowledge them. In the middle of March 1834, soon after their strike had begun, he made an appearance at Jefferson Hall in Lowell, both to encourage the women in their organizing activities and to critique their goals. He urged them to make a shorter workday their first concern, arguing that their lengthy workdays were currently constructed "merely to satisfy the unjust and unreasonable demands of avaricious employers."44 By ignoring the issue of wages, Douglass did not show much sensitivity to the plight of workingwomen or their demand for a wage level that, Thomas Dublin has pointed out, carried with it economic independence. Indeed, Douglass encompassed the female discourse of labor protest within that of the men, subordinating the issue of wages, which women had put forth, to the issue of time. Despite his reservations about their goals, Douglass applauded their organization. Indeed, he saw a potential audience for a new female labor newspaper (since The Artisan was not interested in appealing to them) he planned to call The Female Advocate and

42. The Artisan, November 9, 1833.

43. The Artisan, September 26, 1833.

44. The Artisan, Mareh 22, 1834.

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### Bibliography entry:

Murphy, Teresa Anne. *Ten Hours' Labor: Religion, Reform, and Gender in Early New England*. Ithaca: Cornell University Press, 1992.

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### Shortened citation:

Murphy, *Ten Hours' Labor*, 51-52.

CHAPTER 8 · SECONDARY SOURCE S8.24

# Chants Democratic: New York City and the Rise of the American Working Class, 1788–1850

Sean Wilentz

| | |
|---|---|
| WORK | Chants Democratic: New York City and the Rise of the American Working Class, 1788–1850 |
| SELECTION | Radicalism and the Union |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages 253-254 · Oxford University Press, 1984. |

## Excerpt

The power, the possibilities, and the limitations of these radical notions and the GTU's consciousness of class became fully clear during the events of 1836. To understand these matters, however, requires looking well beyond the trade unions and the GTU. Many other kinds of unions appealed to New York's craft workers and their employers in the 18308, each of them with professed republican intents. Some complicated the trade unionists' efforts, others clashed directly with GTU. Each affected the others. Each by turn shaped the progress and the meaning of the journeymen's revolt.

## Chicago Citations

**Bibliography entry:**

Wilentz, Sean. *Chants Democratic: New York City and the Rise of the American Working Class, 1788–1850*. New York: Oxford University Press, 1984.

**Footnote citation:**

Sean Wilentz, *Chants Democratic: New York City and the Rise of the American Working Class, 1788–1850* (New York: Oxford University Press, 1984), 253-254.

**Shortened citation:**

Wilentz, *Chants Democratic*, 253-254.

CHAPTER 8 · SECONDARY SOURCE S8.25

# Most Uncommon Jacksonians: The Radical Leaders of the Early Labor Movement

Edward Pessen

| | |
|---|---|
| WORK | Most Uncommon Jacksonians: The Radical Leaders of the Early Labor Movement |
| SELECTION | The Leaders |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages 98-99 · State University of New York Press, 1967. |

## Excerpt

What significant generalizations are afforded by the varied labor careers of the unionists? These leaders of the early trades' union movement differ markedly from their present-day counterparts. They were not business unionists. A Luther and a Douglas were social reform agitators, as well as trades' union leaders, their interests ranging far beyond those problems directly relevant to unions. Varied types of affiliation to the labor movement could bestow leadership on an individual. A man could be an active officer, like Commerford, an editor of a sympathetic journal, like Brothers, a fiery orator or pamphleteer, like Fisk, and be accounted a leading spokesman for American labor in each case.

A number of the early leaders seemed interested primarily in political careers. Moore, Slamm, and English used their union careers as springboards from which to leap into Democratic party politics. While they did not give up their labor sympathies, it seems clear that they considered the trades' union movement a means to an end.

Most of the leaders spent only a short time in the labor movement. Luther, Commerford, and Ferral, who tried to organize workingmen and who remained active in various labor organizations for a number of years, were unusual in their staying power.

They did not lead trades' unions because they had worked up from the ranks, for the most part. Oratorical ability and power of pen, rather than long years spent in a trade, determined the parts played by Douglas, English, Slamm, Moore, and even the "carpenter," Luther.

The unique characteristics of the Jacksonian labor leaders were very much the product of the equally unique movement they led. Short-lived unions determined the brief careers of their leaders. A labor movement whose members hoped to be spared the dismal experience of a factory system or their reduction to the status of permanent wage workers, could and did easily proffer leadership to men who were not themselves workers. The time was ripe for men interested in leading labor primarily because they were convinced they knew the path to its redemption. In such an atmosphere there was room at the top of the labor movement for social reformers and relatively educated men, as well as for dedicated journeymen mechanics.

## Chicago Citations

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Pessen, Edward. *Most Uncommon Jacksonians: The Radical Leaders of the Early Labor Movement*. Albany: State University of New York Press, 1967.

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**Shortened citation:**

Pessen, *Most Uncommon Jacksonians*, 98-99.

CHAPTER 8 · SECONDARY SOURCE S8.26

# Ten Hours' Labor: Religion, Reform, and Gender in Early New England

Teresa Anne Murphy

| | |
|---|---|
| WORK | Ten Hours' Labor: Religion, Reform, and Gender in Early New England |
| SELECTION | Introduction |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages 5-6 · Cornell University Press, 1992. |

## Excerpt

My argument in this book is that many working people were unwilling to cede control of religion and moral reform to the middle class. In part, their perspective arose out of the popular evangelicalism of factory towns which challenged the authority of educated elites. Moral reform movements, such as the Washingtonians, did the same, inverting traditional hierarchies and critiquing the pretensions of middle-class piety. Labor activists further elaborated these cultural conflicts as they moved beyond criticism, appropriating middle-class prerogatives in dictating moral standards, and attacking the social relations of paternalism that were so central to New England labor practices.

Many of the labor activists were evangelically inspired and committed to a broad range of reform activities. But religion and reform provided more than ideological commitment for participants, they also provided a common linguistic currency for the largely Protestant working people of New England. There were differences, however. The language of labor protest was far more historically situated than the language of religion and reform, and it was more attuned to differences of economic circumstance and industrial development. This in itself made labor reform far more threatening to the social order than revivals and temperance meetings.

The fact that religion and reform were shared languages rather than shared ideologies is an important point. The same language can be common to a large group of people, but the words can be given different meanings depending on who says them, how they are spoken, and under what circumstances. In this way the words are given different "accents." It is a process that allows for both communication and conflict as different groups struggle to control the meaning of the words.[8]

## Author's Notes

8. V. N. Volosinov uses the term "accents" to describe the way in which different social classes compete to impart their own meanings to particular signs, resulting in their multi-accentuality. Particularly pertinent for the discussion which follows is Volosinov's observation that "a sign that has been withdrawn rom the pressures of social struggle—which, so to speak, crosses beyond the pale of the class struggle inevitably loses force, degenerating into allegory and becoming the object not of live social intelligibility but of philological comprehension. Marxism and the Philosophy of Language (Cambridge, Mass., 1973), 22-25. For further elaboration on the way in which this theory of multi-accentualitv can be applied, see Stuart Hall, "Deconstructing the Popular," in People's History and Social Theory, ed. Raphael Samuel (London, 1981); Michael Denning, Mechanic Accents: Dime Novels and Working-Class Culture in America (New York, 1987), pp. 82-84, and Mary Kupiec Cayton, "The Making of an American Prophet: Emerson, His Audiences, and the Rise of the Culture Industry in Nineteenth- Century America," American Historical Review 92 (June 1987): 597-620.

## Chicago Citations

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Murphy, Teresa Anne. *Ten Hours' Labor: Religion, Reform, and Gender in Early New England*. Ithaca: Cornell University Press, 1992.

**Footnote citation:**

Teresa Anne Murphy, *Ten Hours' Labor: Religion, Reform, and Gender in Early New England* (Ithaca: Cornell University Press, 1992), 5-6.

**Shortened citation:**

Murphy, *Ten Hours' Labor*, 5-6.

CHAPTER 8 · SECONDARY SOURCE S8.27

# How the Irish Became White

**Noel Ignatiev**

| | |
|---|---|
| **WORK** | How the Irish Became White |
| **SELECTION** | Afterword |
| **SOURCE LOCATOR** | Original pages 185-186 · Routledge, 1995. |

## Excerpt

Apparently the labor historians have made little progress since Du Bois wrote those lines. The survey of the history of class struggle in America is yet to be written. There are, however, several recent books that represent a new departure. The first of these is The Rise and Fall of the White Republic by Alexander Saxton.[18] The author sees little difficulty in understanding how the theory of white superiority arose out of the need to vindicate a class of people that grew rich from the slave trade, slavery, and the expropriation of land from nonwhite populations; the more formidable problem is to explain why nonslaveholding whites acquiesced either in planter dominance or its justifications. The Rise and Fall, then, is a study of the role of white supremacy in legitimating the changing class coalitions that ruled the U.S. in the nineteenth century. Contrary to the fictions of the white labor apologists, "the hard side of racism generally appeared in nineteenth-century America as a corollary to egalitarianism" (186). Whiggery was shaped, above all, by class position; within the Whig social hierarchy, "racial difference could be viewed... [as] simply one among many" (70). Northern Whig employers felt the greatest threat from the insurgent immigrant population, while their attitude toward nonwhites was often one of tolerant condescension. For the Jacksonians, needing to cement a coalition based on white egalitarianism, racial distinctions were central. "Their natural proclivity was to the hard side of racism" (120). Accordingly,"class differentials dissolve into a sentimental oneness of the white herrenvolk" (123). David Roediger also explores the problem of white ideology, with specific attention to the working class. He asks "why the white working class settles for being white" (6) and finds the answer in Du Bois's notion of the "public and psychological wage." The "pleasures of whiteness could function as a wage" (13) which led "many workers [to] define themselves as white" (6). To trace the evolution and effects of that wage is the task of The Wages of Whiteness. Although Roediger locates himself within the "broad tradition" of the New Labor History, and uses Marxist tools, he acknowledges that "the new labor history has hesitated to explore 'whiteness' and white supremacy as creations, in part, of the white working class itself" (9) and that "the main body of writing by white Marxists in the United States has both 'naturalized' whiteness and oversimplified race, reproduc[ing] the weaknesses of both American liberalism and neo-conservatism" (6). "Working class formation and the systematic development of a sense of whiteness went hand in hand for the U.S.white working class," writes Roediger (8). Ifthe color line paid a "public and psychological wage," the cost was a "debased republicanism," condemnation to "lifelong wage labor" (55). He concludes with an appropriate symbol: by the end of Reconstruction, "white workers were still tragically set on keeping even John Henry out of the House of Labor" (181).[19] Another study which sheds light on race formation is Richard Williams, Hierarchical Structures and Social Value. According to Williams, some people from Africa became unfree laborers in America because, at a time when the plantations of the Western Hemisphere were crying for labor, West African societies produced a surplus population that could not be exploited at home. "If Europeans had been assigned to [the unfree labor slot] the mark of vertical classification...would have been something other than skin pigmentation" (85-6). In short, people from Africa were not enslaved because they were black; rather, they were defined as black because they were enslaved. Turning his attention to Ireland, Williams traces the developments that ultimately led to the formation of a massive surplus population following the Napoleonic Wars. "The expulsion of a portion of the peasantry from Ireland has become the 'Irish migration'... " (132). "Ethnicity," he argues, "cannot exist without race" (2). In Britain, the Irish constituted a subject race. Because blackness was the badge of the slave in America, people from Ireland who went there entered the free labor system, which made them part of the dominant race. As unskilled workers, they occupied the lowest place within it. Ethnicity marked the spot. Through a process parallel to the creation of race, "a segment of Irish society became identified as the Irish in the United States" (100). Another work searching out the origins of whiteness is Theodore W. Allen's, The Invention of the White Race. Allen declares that, when the first

## Author's Notes

18. I have been led to this view in part by reflecting on recent events in Howard Beach and Bensonhurst, New York City.

19. Michael Feldberg, The Turbulent Era: Riot and Disorder in Jacksonian America (New York, 1980), 4-5; David Grimsted, "Rioting in Its Jacksonian Setting," American Historical Review 77: 2 (April 1972):361-97. There is a voluminous theoretical and documentary literature on rioting in Jacksonian America, much of it stimulated by events of the 1960s.

## Chicago Citations

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**Footnote citation:**

Noel Ignatiev, *How the Irish Became White* (New York: Routledge, 1995), 185-186.

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Ignatiev, *How the Irish Became White*, 185-186.

CHAPTER 8 · SECONDARY SOURCE S8.28

# City of Women: Sex and Class in New York, 1789–1860

Christine Stansell

| | |
|---|---|
| WORK | City of Women: Sex and Class in New York, 1789–1860 |
| SELECTION | Excerpt from the supplied edition |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages 44-45 · Alfred A. Knopf, 1986. |

## Excerpt

The political economy of the city of women was distinct, although not unrelated to that of race, ethnicity and occupation. Family situations propelled women into the working class, and the relations of gender gave a distinct shape to the female experience of proletarianization. A woman's age, marital status, the number and age of her children and, above all, the presence or absence of male support determined her position in working class life. Any woman, whether the wife of a prosperous artisan or a day laborer's daughter, was vulnerable to extreme poverty if, for some reason, she lost the support of a man. With the expansion of manufacturing employment after 1830, young single women might earn some kind of a living for themselves, but married women with children experienced the loss of men's wages, either through death or desertion, as devastating. The seasonal moves that men made to find work enhanced their women's vulnerability. Tramping artisans and migrant laborers could die on the road or take advantage of the moment to abandon their families, and even loyal husbands could find it hard to get news and money back to children and wives in New York. The frequency of occupationally related accidents and disease in men's employments contributed to a high rate of male mortality, which also left many women as the breadwinners for their families. [12] Men, too, suffered when their wives died or left them. The loss of women's housekeeping services, along with whatever income they contributed, created hardships for widowers and deserted husbands. Nonetheless, a woman's absence alone was not sufficient to imperil a husband's livelihood, while a wife cast on her own faced the specter of the Almshouse.

## Author's Notes

12. Richard Stott stresses that the city's male labor market was regionally based, thus necessitating that men travel frequently outside the city for work. "Worker in the Metropolis," p. ror. Contemporary testimony about the mobility of male laborers can be found in the Society for the Reformation of Juvenile Delinquents, Fifteenth Annual Report (New York, 1850), p. 9; Matthew Carey, "Essay on the Public Charities of Philadelphia," Miscellaneous Essays (Philadelphia, 1830), pp. r72-73. Both Sally Alexander in "Women's Work in Nineteenth Century London; A Study of the Years 1820-50," in The Rights and Wrongs of Women, ed. Juliet Mitchell and Ann Oakley (Harmondsworth, Eng., 1976), p. 80, and Barbara Taylor in Eve and the New Jerusalem, pp. 203, 244, 336, note the growing instability of male support among British laboring people. See also the general comments on the numbers of women in New York bereft of male support in the Association for the Asylum for Lying-In Women (AALW), Sixth Annual Report (New York, 1829) and Commis sioner of the Almshouse, Annual Report (New York, 1847), p. 39. On male mortality see Carol Groneman Pernicone, "'The Bloody Ould Sixth': A Social Analysis of a New York City Working-Class Community in the Mid-Nineteenth Century" (Ph.D. diss., University of Rochester, 1973), p. 29.

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**Shortened citation:**

Stansell, *City of Women*, 44-45.

CHAPTER 8 · SECONDARY SOURCE S8.29

# Nativism and Slavery: The Northern Know Nothings and the Politics of the 1850s

Tyler Anbinder

| | |
|---|---|
| WORK | Nativism and Slavery: The Northern Know Nothings and the Politics of the 1850s |
| SELECTION | The Ideology of the Know Nothing Party |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages 115-116 · Oxford University Press, 1992. |

## Excerpt

Although the pope seemed a distant threat to many Americans, Know Nothings insisted that Catholic priests carried out the pontiff's subversive schemes in America. "It is the constant plotting of these Jesuitical craftsmen that we resist," argued nativists, especially "their endeavors to unite Church and State, and render both subservient to the nod of the Pope." Know Nothings believed that Catholics could never disobey their priests, because the priest might then reveal secrets divulged in the confessional or withhold absolution. This gave priests extraordinary power, which they used to enforce conformity amongst the laity. Furthermore, most American priests had been born abroad and had never taken oaths of citizenship. This reinforced the notion that their loyalties lay ultimately with Rome and convinced many natives that the power of priests ought to be curtailed.[24] Following a traditional theme of anti-Catholicism, Know Nothings also accused priests of sexual licentiousness. Richard Hofstadter noted that "anti-Catholicism has always been the pornography of the Puritan," and the popularity of Maria Monk's convent "revelations" demonstrates that the Protestant obsession with sexual impropriety by the priesthood preceded the Know Nothings by many years. The notion that convents provided the setting for illicit sex was so prevalent that customers commonly referred to nineteenth-century brothels as "nunneries."[25] While Know Nothing journals did not describe convent life in the sordid detail provided in convent exposés, their language left no doubt as to what they imagined went on within their walls. "Convents are the very hot-beds of lust and debauchery," reported one Know Nothing journal, while another described how they were "impregnated with vice and crime." Priests in convents exercised the most "shocking licentiousness and most unmitigated despotism over the hearts, minds, and persons of the nuns." Know Nothings asserted that the priests' authority allowed them to cover up their convent indiscretions by condemning their victims to a life of cloistered silence.[26]

## Author's Notes

24. *Pottsville Miner's Journal*, May 20, 1854 (quotation); *Christian Advocate and Journal* [a leading Methodist organ] in *Harrisburg Herald*, Sept. 1, Oct. 6 (quotation), 1854; *Albany State Register*, Sept. 15, 1855; *Philadelphia News* in *Clearfield [Pennsylvania] Raftsman's Journal*, Dec. 5, 1855; *Hartford Courant*, Nov. 26, 1855.

25. Richard Hofstadter, *The Paranoid Style in American Politics* (New York: Knopf, 1965), 21; Billington, *Protestant Crusade*, 68–76, 98–108.

26. *Harrisburg Herald*, Nov. 7, 1854 (quotation); *Boston Know Nothing*, May 6, 1854 (quotation); *Clearfield [Pennsylvania] Raftsman's Journal*, Dec. 12, 1855 (quotation); *Know Nothing Almanac* (1855): 50, (1856), 29, 49–52; *Cleveland Express*, July 27, 1854; *Cincinnati Dollar Times*, Aug. 3, 1854.

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**Shortened citation:**

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CHAPTER 8 · SECONDARY SOURCE S8.30

# How the Irish Became White

Noel Ignatiev

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|---|---|
| WORK | How the Irish Became White |
| SELECTION | Excerpt from the supplied edition |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages 98-100 · Routledge, 1995. |

## Excerpt

Some modern scholars have joined Finch in pointing to labor competition as the cause of intergroup animosities within the working class, and in particular animosity between Irish- and Afro-Americans, who together made up the bulk of America's unskilled proletariat.[23] However, there is nothing distinctively racial in what Finch recounted of the relations among black and immigrant workers. He might have been describing conflicts between Irish and Germans, or among Irish from different counties, with no assumption of racial favoritism. While labor competition explains some things, unless its operation is specified, identifying it as the source of intergroup tensions raises more questions than it answers. In the ideal situation, workers contracting for the sale of their labor power compete as individuals, not as groups. And this is even true to some extent in the real world: no employer ever hired "the Irish" or "the Afro-Americans"; individual persons compete to fill specific openings. Under the capitalist system, all workers compete for jobs. The competition gives rise to animosity among them; but normally it also gives rise to its opposite, unity. It is not free competition that leads to enduring animosity, but its absence. Race becomes a social fact at the moment "racial" identification begins to impose barriers to free competition among atomized and otherwise interchangeable individuals. To the extent it does so, the greatest individual competition takes place not between groups but within each group. In the period under consideration the most intense and desperate labor competition was not between Irish and free Negroes, but within each of the two groups, and no one has ever suggested that it presented an insurmountable obstacle to the cohesion of either. If the experience of Cork and Longford men killing each other on the canal projects taught them that it was to their mutual advantage to come together, and if the rivalry among Irish and Germans eventually gave way to cooperative relations, why did the competition among Irish- and Afro-American laborers fail to lead to a mutual appreciation of the need for unity? The answer is that the competition among these two groups did not take place under normal circumstances, but was distorted by the color line, what O'Connell called something in the "atmosphere" of America. Finch himself recognized that what was going on was more than simple labor competition. "The working people reason thus," he continued.

Competition among free white working men here is even now reducing our wages daily; but if the blacks were to be emancipated, probably hundreds of thousands of them would migrate into these northern States, and the competition for employment would consequently be so much increased, that wages would speedily be as low, or lower here, than they are in England; better, therefore, for us, that they remain slaves as they are. Hence we see why the American abolitionists of slavery are more unpopular among these parties in America, than Socialists are among the priests and upper classes in England-hence we see why the repeal associations in Cincinnati wrote to O'Connell in defence of slavery, and why many repeal associations in the United States, particularly in the south, broke up and refused to give any more assistance to the repealers in Ireland, after receiving his denunciations of that accursed system.

## Author's Notes

23. See for example, Leon F.Litwack, North of Slavery: The Negro in the Free States, 1790-1860 (Chicago, 1961), 153-186.

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CHAPTER 8 · SECONDARY SOURCE S8.31

# Nativism and Slavery: The Northern Know Nothings and the Politics of the 1850s

**Tyler Anbinder**

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|---|---|
| **WORK** | Nativism and Slavery: The Northern Know Nothings and the Politics of the 1850s |
| **SELECTION** | Introduction |
| **SOURCE LOCATOR** | Original pages Introduction (unpaginated supplied PDF) · Oxford University Press, 1992. |

## Excerpt

This work fills this historiographic gap by presenting the first detailed survey of the Know Nothing party in the North. The study focuses to a great extent on state politics, in part because this was the arena in which the Know Nothings exerted the greatest influence, and in part because the organization differed tremendously from state to state. Nonetheless, certain broad themes and recurrent issues unify the story. The first is the role of the slavery controversy in the rise and fall of the Know Nothing party. Northern voters had grown increasingly disenchanted with the Whig and Democratic parties during the early 1850s, and this sentiment peaked after Congress enacted the Kansas-Nebraska bill. Many Northerners decided to abandon their old parties at this time in order to demonstrate their disgust with the new law, and the Know Nothings, who had acquired an anti-slavery reputation, attracted many of these disgruntled voters. Without the political crisis caused primarily by the Kansas-Nebraska Act, and the Know Nothings' anti-slavery reputation, the Know Nothings would never have enjoyed such phenomenal success. Slavery, not nativism, destroyed the second American party system. But because many Northerners chose to express their anti-slavery sentiment through the Know Nothing organization, the Republican party did not immediately benefit from the fallout over the Kansas-Nebraska Act. The slavery issue also contributed to the Know Nothings' speedy demise, because when the Order appeared to equivocate on the slavery-extension issue at its national convention in 1855, most Northerners abandoned the organization and joined the Republican party. The depth of anti-Catholic sentiment in the United States forms a second theme of this study. Although the Know Nothings' anti-slavery stance drew many Northerners to the Order who would have ordinarily remained faithful to mainstream political parties, these citizens would not have become Know Nothings had they not also sympathized with its anti-Catholic agenda.

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Anbinder, *Nativism and Slavery*, Introduction (unpaginated supplied PDF).

CHAPTER 8 · SECONDARY SOURCE S8.32

# The Panic of 1819: The First Great Depression

Andrew H. Browning

| | |
|---|---|
| WORK | The Panic of 1819: The First Great Depression |
| SELECTION | Three Revolutions: Market, Transportation, Corporation |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages 49-50 · University of Missouri Press, 2019. |

## Excerpt

Shelby had in fact become wealthy through interstate commerce in livestock, and he and Clay both raised hemp for the cordage and sailcloth industries. Clay, like modern politicians, was happy to invoke a nostalgic image of rural domestic virtue, but the self-sufficient farm was already becoming a thing of the past. By 1820 the United States was entering its second year of depression following the Panic of 1819. There had been hard times before in American memory, but this depression was different because the country was now different; subsistence farming was rapidly giving way to an interdependent network of commercial activity, more and more people were employed for wages, and members of the middle class were, for the first time, investing in corporate stock. Rich investors like Robert Morris ("the financier of the Revolution") had been wiped out when a speculative bubble burst in 1797, but the impact of that crash had been limited to the major cities and the well-to-do. A financial crisis in 1792 had sent Hamilton's former assistant treasury secretary, William Duer, to debtors' prison, but it was not much felt outside of New York and was over in a month or two. The Mississippi Bubble and South Sea Bubble were still remembered for their insider trading and stockholder panics, but they had happened on the other side of the ocean, in a world where only the privileged felt their effects. They remained cautionary tales, but they were now nearly a century in the past.[2]

The economic "pressure" that hit big-city merchants and northern cotton mills in 1815 and 1816 spread down the Ohio River in 1817 and 1818, struck western land speculators and southern planters in 1819, and reached St. Louis and the Missouri Territory by 1820. It was an unprecedented nationwide depression in an increasingly complex economy: it hurt farmers, mill hands, shopkeepers, and stockholders in turnpikes and canal companies. The extent of the "hard times" was only possible because regions of the country and sectors of the economy were linked together as never before. The successors to Washington and Jefferson's Revolutionary generation were going through their own revolution—three of them, in fact: two that have become familiar as the Market Revolution and Transportation Revolution of the antebellum 1800s, and a less well-known Corporation Revolution that helped make the other two possible. For the first time, cash income became a part of almost every American's calculations. The new economy made enormous fortunes, but its greatest effects were achieved in the more modest strata of society: the small farmers who became commodity traders and the artisans who became manufacturers all connected local markets to regional and national networks. The historian Joyce Appleby argues that they had a greater effect on the transformation of the economy than bankers or factory owners. She underlines the market's importance even to many of the rural poor "for whom the conspicuous material advances of their lifetime cemented their attachment to both the nation and its economic prosperity." To Richard Ellis, one of the first historians to draw attention to the Market Revolution, it is "the key development that explains the transition from what is known as Jeffersonian Democracy to what is known as Jacksonian Democracy in United States History."[3]

## Author's Notes

2. Jefferson to Rush, Jan. 22, 1819, in Founders Online.

3. Adams to Jefferson, Dec. 21, 1819, in ibid.

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**Bibliography entry:**

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Browning, *The Panic of 1819*, 49-50.

CHAPTER 8 · SECONDARY SOURCE S8.33

# The Market Revolution in America: Liberty, Ambition, and the Eclipse of the Common Good

John Lauritz Larson

| | |
|---|---|
| WORK | The Market Revolution in America: Liberty, Ambition, and the Eclipse of the Common Good |
| SELECTION | What Do We Mean by a Market Revolution in America? |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages 8-9 · Cambridge University Press, 2009. |

## Excerpt

Finally, what of capitalism and the capitalist system? Historians and economists argue bitterly over the meaning of these terms and when they apply to early American society. Much of the quarrel can be attributed to precise (but different) definitions that make it possible to date the "rise of capitalism" to the 1620s, the 1740s, the 1790s, or the 1830s. A second line of controversy swirls around slavery and the nature of slave-based enterprise within a free-market system. Generations of historians, building on theoretical distinctions rooted in the writings of Karl Marx, portrayed the plantation economies of the southern colonies and states as fundamentally different from the mixed commercial-agricultural systems found in middle and northern states. More recent students have called attention to hard-driving, man-onthe-make planters, especially in the new slave states of the antebellum West, and question just how "backward" slaveholders really were. At the center of all these arguments lies the question: When did the cold calculus of the marketplace trump other considerations in the making of private decisions by ordinary individuals? Long ago, Marx predicted that market forces would displace sentimental, familial, religious, or humanitarian values in a mature capitalist system; but while the tendency has been in that direction, it remains unclear just when — if ever — such a total transition took place. Before the market revolution, there were markets, to be sure: Profits were taken, greed exhibited, goods produced and exchanged. But greed was not normative, and an individual's behavior might as often contradict as conform to the dictates of economic interest. After the market revolution, "hard-headed" economic logic sought to dominate the process of evaluating all things. Individual identity dissolved into anonymity, commitment into contract, vocation into work, a living into a wage. The transformation never was absolute or complete. Long after the market revolution, people continued (and continue still) to exhibit behaviors (labeled "irrational") that contravened the expectations of economists. But there must have been a tipping point in history before which people did not believe — or did not accept it as natural and inevitable — that the market should be the universal arbiter of interests. After that point, whether happily or not, people came to believe that social and material life likely would not (could not?) be otherwise. At that point, which may have lasted a generation, a year, or one "eureka" moment, people experienced the market revolution and entered an era of capitalist relations. That market revolution is the subject of this book. It is this tipping point for which we search in the lives of antebellum Americans, when they came to believe (correctly or not) that impersonal market forces had disabled the fabric of personal, familial, and cultural connections by which people earlier had tried to mitigate the hard facts of material life. It probably does not explain every personal and political decision made during the antebellum decades, but this market revolution was on the minds of nearly everyone in the United States between the Revolution and the Civil War, and it colored (if it did not dictate) their reaction to a host of public issues ranging from banking and money to

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**Shortened citation:**

Larson, *The Market Revolution in America*, 8-9.

CHAPTER 8 · SECONDARY SOURCE S8.34

# Law and the Conditions of Freedom in the Nineteenth-Century United States

James Willard Hurst

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|---|---|
| WORK | Law and the Conditions of Freedom in the Nineteenth-Century United States |
| SELECTION | Law and the Conditions of Freedom |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages 16-17 · University of Wisconsin Press, 1956. |

## Excerpt

Thus the grant of corporate status became a notable issue in the years of Jacksonian Democracy. This did, indeed, involve serious issues concerning the power structure of the society; the Jacksonian polemics on this score forecast the issues in the background of the Granger movement and the Sherman Act. But, aside from the sensitive matter of banks, currency, and credit, the demand for freer incorporation, deep down, fitted the dominant temper of the times, Jacksonian as well as Whig. Hence the Jacksonians appear increasingly uncomfortable in their opposition. The special charters which fill so many bulky volumes of state session laws of 1830-1880 are on the whole disappointing to a searcher for melodrama or moral conflict. They tend soon to fall into patterns; quite evidently most of them answered to rather standard demands for the means of reaching rather standard business ends. Mostly their provisions deal with powers or privileges which strike a twentieth-century observer as commonplaces of modern business. The reader must scan their standardized clauses with a very careful eye if he would find the small variations which may represent the hidden grab or privilege which historical legend associates with the special charter era. When the special provisions are found, few are such as to give rise to any plausible suspicion that they represent sinister gain at the expense of public welfare. The more familiar one becomes with nineteenth-century special charters, the more he suspects that if there was corruption it likely took the form of charging unofficial toll for steering perfectly routine charters through the bustle of a session. Many special charters set limitations on corporate life, on landholdings of the corporation, and on its capital, to remind us of the contemporary distrust. Yet the charters are there on the books by the hundreds. That legislatures filled with turbulent debate over the privilege of incorporation nonetheless ground out special charters in quantity for fifty years indicates that some very basic policy of the times was being fulfilled. The later course of the public debate showed this; with considerable anticlimax, after the melodrama of earlier years, a main argument against continued special chartering came to be that it put an undue drain on the time of legislatures in meeting a standard and routine demand. Jacksonian Democracy reached its resolution of the matter by finding that the public interest was satisfied if the privilege of incorporation for ordinary business purposes was made available to all on equal terms.'°

The substance of what business wanted from law was the provision for ordinary use of an organization through which entrepreneurs could better mobilize and release economic energy. Partly this business demand was to get rid of a limiting governmental policy; it sought release of the law's jealously restrictive control over this type of association. But it is characteristic of the nineteenth century that there was here also a demand for positive help from the law. Merely to be let alone to combine capital was not the substance of the entrepreneurs' desire. Here, as so often, a lively and pervasive sense of capital scarcity, relative to our opportunities, supplied the dynamic of public policy. One did not mobilize and discipline scattered resources merely by exhorting government to keep its hands off. Entrepreneurs wanted the positive prestige of the sanction of the state implicit in the charter grant. They wanted the aid of an orderly capital subscription procedure under which capital could be fed into the enterprise on a defined installment plan, with provisions for periodic assessments of stockholders and forfeitures to enforce assessments. The influence of provisions for the limited liability of corporate stockholders for the debts of the business has perhaps been exaggerated as a source of the pressure for incorporation.

But, whatever the relative weight of this element, there is no doubt that the grant of the limited liability privilege was sought as a positive aid by law to the enlistment of capital. Entrepreneurs wanted, too, a form of organization which firmly and broadly delegated power over mobilized capital to managers and directors.

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Hurst, *Law and the Conditions of Freedom in the Nineteenth-Century United States*, 16-17.

CHAPTER 8 · SECONDARY SOURCE S8.35

# Internal Improvement: National Public Works and the Promise of Popular Government in the Early United States

John Lauritz Larson

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|---|---|
| WORK | Internal Improvement: National Public Works and the Promise of Popular Government in the Early United States |
| SELECTION | Internal Improvement and Constitutional Stalemate |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages 140-141 · University of North Carolina Press, 2001. |

## Excerpt

Monroe's pronouncement only heightened the stalemate. The improvers' majority in the House disappeared as the vote to override failed 68 to 72. Congress stood prohibited from doing what the people (and the president) wanted because the guardians of constitutional balance feared the prospect of further encroachment. By demanding an amendment that could not be secured, Monroe empowered the neo-Antifederalists he clearly intended to disarm, yet by approving of a system of roads and canals he also encouraged the improvers to cling to their agenda. An amendment would clear away objections, but improvers dared not press for it now because the neo-Antifederalists had staked the limits of a redefined Union far less powerful than the one that was ratified originally. If they killed an internal improvement amendment, this could affirm their new interpretation and undermine powers long acknowledged, opening the Constitution to eventual recision, clause by clause. As long as states' rights proponents insisted on restoring the confederation model, nationalistic improvers pressed ahead wherever they found votes to act—thereby proving themselves "guilty" of aggressively loose construction."

Renewed talk about a system of surveys, together with the controversy stirred by Monroe's veto of the Cumberland Road toll gate bill, produced another flurry of popular demands from the states and private corporations for federal aid to roads and canals. Most appeals were transparently self-interested, but some were more generous than others. Anticipating aid to the Potomac navigation, for example, the legislature of Maryland promised to "highly approbate, and zealously co-operate" with any program of palais nig "best Ealenlonet! for the pase pn... Pr ey ee ee Se ee a begged for land grants and aid to buud roads into nearby territories, mixing freely as justifications military defense, postal service, the government's duty to facilitate settlement, and the increasing value of lands in the public domain once internal improvements were made. Opponents still warned that any gift was "but a beginning" that would run into endless commitments; but often (as in the case of a Tennessee congressman speaking against a road in Michigan) these principled objections "fell" from members whose states begged preferment themselves. In 1823 the House revisited the General Survey Bill. Philip Pendleton Barbour, now speaker of the House, moved to kill it, trying to "determine at once" if a majority "would or would not commence" a "system" he believed was unconstitutional. Pennsylvania's Hemphill, author of the bill, agreed that its purpose was to foster the design of a "general system," and then he spoke for hours reviewing all the proofs for internal improvement. Barbour's motion failed in a thinly attended House, after which the bill itself was tabled. The next day Silas Wood of New York (revealing that state's conversion to strict construction now that the Erie Canal was successful) delivered the contrary argument, decrying the "fashionable" habit, "the cant of the day," of calling every subject of "general utility" a "national subject." Once again the bill was tabled by a close vote, and then a large majority (including many friends of the bill) refused to consider it further."

The demand for internal improvements clearly was mounting, and if the "cant of the day," changed the minds of no states' rights members of Congress, it seemed increasingly to represent the popular desires of the people. Traveling widely through Kentucky and Ohio during his brief retirement from Congress (collecting debts for the national bank

and support for his presidential campaign), Henry Clay decided that the people were ready to support his developmental vision, and he prepared to return to Washington. Secretary of War Calhoun (another candidate) arrived at the same conclusion: "The people are for internal improvement, domestick manufacturers, &c., &c." Addressing the incoming lawmakers in December 1823, President Monroe opened a hole in his own constitutional levee by suggesting that Congress might "authorize by an adequate appropriation" (no amendment required) the assignment of army engineers to surveying roads and canals—an invitation congressmen eagerly accepted. It looked as if the Eighteenth Congress finally would measure the mood of the country and test the progress of consolidation."[o] A Legislative Victory Filled with hope, Congressman Hemphill reintroduced his bill for a system of surveys by army engineers, this time shrewdly leaving all route selection to neseidantial diecratinn and ctreccine that no constitutional objection could be

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Larson, *Internal Improvement*, 140-141.

CHAPTER 8 · SECONDARY SOURCE S8.36

# Internal Improvement: National Public Works and the Promise of Popular Government in the Early United States

John Lauritz Larson

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|---|---|
| WORK | Internal Improvement: National Public Works and the Promise of Popular Government in the Early United States |
| SELECTION | The Politics of Internal Improvement |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages 171-173 · University of North Carolina Press, 2001. |

## Excerpt

The effect of Rives's resolution was to show friends of Andrew Jackson how they could oppose the Adams administration on internal improvement without embracing the cause of old radicals such as Macon and Randolph. Voters in the West naturally were drawn by sentiment to Jackson—his violence, heroism, character, primitive rhetoric, and humble origins; but westerners equally were drawn by interest to internal improvements, and they would not join a party built on states' rights and hostility to federal developmental programs. Taking their cues from Rives, members of the Twentieth Congress began presenting themselves as friends of a "system" of improvement yet enemies of executive influence, patronage, corruption, and the rise of a monied "Aristocracy." John Eaton (of all people)—author of The Letters of Wyoming and a recognized voice of the Jackson camp—gave a speech worthy of the early Calhoun, praising the "stronger bond of Union" that resulted from improvements and urging the adoption of "such measures" as would "make the citizens of this extended continent one People." At the same time friends and enemies of internal improvement rushed to document ' their opposition to this administration's alleged excesses. "No great system... had been reported to Congress," complained Louis McLane: "The Secretary of War had departed entirely from the object of the law of '24." By now sixty-nine separate surveys had been commenced and over thirty more were pending. Robert Y. Hayne, who had once asked Calhoun why the Charleston harbor found no place in his national system, now said that he had learned a great lesson from supporting the General Survey Act: "the most important question, in passing a Jaw, was not 'what' its benefit would be, but to what extent its provisions might be abused."4?

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Larson, *Internal Improvement*, 171-173.

CHAPTER 8 · SECONDARY SOURCE S8.37

# The Artificial River: The Erie Canal and the Paradox of Progress, 1817–1862

Carol Sheriff

| | |
|---|---|
| WORK | The Artificial River: The Erie Canal and the Paradox of Progress, 1817–1862 |
| SELECTION | The Artificial River |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages 20-21 · Hill and Wang, 1996. |

## Excerpt

20 Lhe Artificial Kiver promised to be a very expensive undertaking. When New York conducted its 1808 survey, many of its legislators believed that the federal government would back the project financially. They pointed to the report issued in that same year by Albert Gallatin, Jefferson's Secretary of the Treasury, calling for appropriations for a national system of roads and canals. That report, which laid the groundwork for the funding of the National Road, also mentioned a canal between the Hudson and Lake Ontario. The ensuing debates in Congress centered on whether the proposed canal would benefit the country as a whole or whether it would favor a particular section, while Jefferson and like-minded men also worried that the Constitution did not allow the federal government to finance such projects. Before these questions were decided, the War of 1812 interrupted matters.

That conflict turned the nation's attention and resources elsewhere, while also highlighting for New Yorkers the advantages of an inland waterway. Because fighting took place mostly along the border between New York and Canada, the war accentuated the precarious nature of the Montreal market. A canal would provide access to a more stable market for the nation's western farmers. Moreover, the war and the embargoes leading up to it set off a boom in manufacturing in the northeastern states. Since Americans could no longer legally trade with Great Britain for manufactured goods, they had to spin and weave their own textiles and sew their own shoes. The loss of access to European trade made an inexpensive route for western agricultural products even more essential, as a means both to feed industrial workers and their families and to provide raw materials for factories.

New Yorkers still hoped that the federal government would pay for their proposed waterway once peace returned. In 1817, three years after the Treaty of Ghent brought hostilities to an official close, Congress passed an internal improvements bill that included funding for the New York canal, but Madison vetoed the act on his last day in office, citing qualms over its constitutionality. Without an amendment specifically authorizing Congress to fund transportation projects, he argued, the federal government could not legally sponsor projects like the Erie Canal, as desirable as those projects might be. Some critics accused Madison of having sectional biases, of not wanting to boost New York, the arch economic rival of his native Virginia. Whatever his motivations, it became clear that any such future transportation projects would have to be undertaken by the states. This was to be an era of state, rather than national, power.!?

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**Shortened citation:**

Sheriff, *The Artificial River*, 20-21.

CHAPTER 8 · SECONDARY SOURCE S8.38

# Private Interest & Public Gain: The Dartmouth College Case, 1819

Francis N. Stites

| | |
|---|---|
| WORK | Private Interest & Public Gain: The Dartmouth College Case, 1819 |
| SELECTION | Blasted Hopes |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages 52-53 · University of Massachusetts Press, 1972. |

## Excerpt

The heart of his opinion was the defense argument that Dartmouth was a public corporation. He followed Marshall in Bank of the United States v. Deveaux (18 09)66 and defined a corporation as “an artificial, invisible body, existing only in contemplation of law.” Arguing that corporations possessed rights and property only “in form” and that “in reality” those rights and property belonged to individuals and the public, the Chief Justice of New Hampshire demonstrated that the old civil-eleemosynary' division of corporations was unsuited to the demands of early nineteenth century America. He proposed a new division into public and private based upon property rights and the objects for which corporations were created.[67]

Private corporations, such as banks, insurance and manufacturing companies, Judge Richardson said, were created for the immediate benefit and advantage of individuals. The property and franchises of private corporations belonged to individuals under the corporate form. Towns and other public corporations were created for public purposes. Their property and franchises were devoted to the object of their incorporation, and the corporators enjoyed no private right other than that of being members. It was only necessary to determine in this case whether the objects for which Dartmouth College was created were public or private. The endowment was of no consequence, since a corporation held property only to enable it to answer the object of its creation, and a gift to a corporation was a gift to those interested in its objects.

Richardson examined the College charter and found that Dartmouth had been incorporated to spread Christianity and knowledge among the Indians and to furnish the best means of education to New Hampshire. “These great purposes are surely, if anything can be, matters of public concern.”68 Since the object was public, Dartmouth College was a public corporation, and the office of trustee was a public trust, as much as the office of governor or judge. As public servants, the trustees had no private right, other than that of being members of the corporation, which they could claim the June act in final form had infringed. Indeed, only the state had an interest, and so there was no founder whose rights the trustees could assert. Law, Richardson declared, was only the will of the sovereign people, and the public servants, the trustees, could not resist the master’s will in a matter that concerned the master alone. With this established, he did not think it necessary to inquire into the legislature’s right to interfere with private corporations. But he did admit that the property of private corporations would stand on the same ground as that of individuals.

## Author's Notes

67. 65 New Hampshire Reports 628. 68.Ibid., 630.

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**Shortened citation:**

Stites, *Private Interest & Public Gain*, 52-53.

CHAPTER 8 · SECONDARY SOURCE S8.39

# Scraping By: Wage Labor, Slavery, and Survival in Early Baltimore

Seth Rockman

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|---|---|
| WORK | Scraping By: Wage Labor, Slavery, and Survival in Early Baltimore |
| SELECTION | Scraping By |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages 40-41 · Johns Hopkins University Press, 2009. |

## Excerpt

In other Southern cities, the free black population was predominantly light skinned, and manumission was frequently the result of being the son or daughter of the owner himself. In places like Charleston or New Orleans, free people of color typically formed a “black middle class,” with men working in skilled trades and in a few cases even owning other African Americans as slaves (protecting their own wives and daughters from paid labor). The situation was quite different in Baltimore, where the free black population was overwhelmingly poor and dark skinned, and owed its freedom to the transformation of the regional economy, not a blood relationship. Free people of color generally entered Baltimore directly out of slavery, with no capital, tools, or training in a craft skill. Fortunate free people of color worked for themselves as carters and laundresses, but most found few job options beyond common labor and domestic service. In those capacities, however, free people of color could be seen as valuable to Baltimore's economy. “Every reasonable person will admit that he respects much more the orderly industrious African than the drunken idle white man, whether emigrant or native,” explained almshouse trustee Thomas W. Griffith. Time and again, Baltimore employers resisted the opportunity to narrow the range of workers at their disposal. Take, for example, their involvement in the colonization movement, an organized effort to remove free people of color from the United States. Whereas some early advocates saw colonization as a humanitarian step toward ending slavery, others hoped to purge the nation of its free black inhabitants. In 1817, Henry Clay, the president of the American Colonization Society (ACS), touted the possibility of exiling a “useless and pernicious” population to Liberia. Baltimore’s Francis Scott Key was a founding member of the ACS, but the vast majority of support in Maryland came from rural slaveholders who saw free blacks as a threat to the future of slaveholding. So invested was Maryland as a whole in the project of deporting black people (especially manumitted slaves) that the state founded its own African colony in the early 1830s. Ships transported over 600 black Marylanders to Africa in the 1830s; only eight passengers hailed from Baltimore. Free people of color in Baltimore denounced the colonization project, and urban slaveholders showed little interest in making exile a condition of manumission. Likewise, most Baltimore employers were uninterested in reducing the scope of the labor pool.®

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CHAPTER 8 · SECONDARY SOURCE S8.40

# Fire & Roses: The Burning of the Charlestown Convent, 1834

Nancy Lusignan Schultz

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|---|---|
| WORK | Fire & Roses: The Burning of the Charlestown Convent, 1834 |
| SELECTION | The Vine Uprooted |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages 165-166 · Free Press, 2000. |

## Excerpt

On the day before the riot, Lyman Beecher gave three anti-Catholic sermons, on Bowdoin Street in the morning, in the Old South in the afternoon, and in Park Street in the evening, each speech lasting roughly an hour.*! In these speeches, Dr. Beecher focused on drumming up support for his school, the Lane Seminary, giving several reasons why this was crucial. The first reason was to train educated preachers for the West. The second, he asserted, was that financial support must come from New England to spread the concept of New England learning. Interestingly, in this section of the speech, he called for religious freedom, and for an end to persecution, at least of Protestant sects. In grand rhetorical style, he saved his strongest reason for last: “that the Roman Catholics of Europe seem to be seeking an asylum from the contentions and revolutions of the old world and a site for the palace of the Pope and the Romish Church in the Great Valley of the Mississippi?’ Beecher later issued this speech as a monograph called A Plea for the West. The most vivid impression that audiences took away from these sermons were the anti-Catholic themes. One who was in the audience was Anna Loring, who gave the following account of Beecher’s inflammatory sermon: Dr. Beecher has at last arrived, and preached last Sunday morning at Mr Winslows—his sermon was upon the condition & prospects of the West, & the influence the Lane Seminary would have upon that section of our country—I think he has laid himself open to be ridicule by those opposed Dy Ue 1dear [sity Wildl that institution could do with he [sic] at the head of it—He gave a very interesting account of the soil, climate &c, and the state of the population many facts most appaling of the Roman Catholicks of its influence & its rapid spreading—that they were establishing schools & nunnerys, for the purpose of educating our children…”

In his sermons against Catholicism, Beecher declared that “the principles of this corrupt church are adverse to our free institutions, from the contempt and hostility which they feel towards all Protestants…. Roman Catholic Europe is pouring her population into the Valley in great abundance; and… that if the subjects of the Pope increased beyond the increase of our own people, in the proportion which they had in the last ten years they would in thirty years more, out number our native inhabitants…. Despotic princes in Europe would empty their coffers of treasure liberally, could they by means of the Romish church, subvert our free institutions and bring into disgrace all ideas of an effective government.” He especially warned against “gratuitous schools” established by the Catholics for the education of Protestant children— *while the children of the subjects of the Pope were left to roam in ignorance, many of them incapable of either reading or writing. Hence the necessity that Protestants should be on the alert in the work of early education.”

After the convent burning, the Protestant newspaper The Christian Examiner published this veiled indictment of Lyman Beecher, referring to him as a “pest”: We doubt not that religious fanaticism, in its lowest and most brutalizing form, had some influence in producing the wickedness which has been perpetrated in Charlestown. It was excited in part by gross calumnies, which had been proved to be unfounded before the deed was committed, and in part perhaps by the writing and preaching of some one or more of those pests of our community, who seem to have little other notion of religion, than it is a subject about which men’s passions may be inflamed, and they may be made to hate each other.‘

## Chicago Citations

**Bibliography entry:**

Schultz, Nancy Lusignan. *Fire & Roses: The Burning of the Charlestown Convent, 1834*. New York: Free Press, 2000.

**Footnote citation:**

Nancy Lusignan Schultz, *Fire & Roses: The Burning of the Charlestown Convent, 1834* (New York: Free Press, 2000), 165-166.

**Shortened citation:**

Schultz, *Fire & Roses*, 165-166.

CHAPTER 8 · SECONDARY SOURCE S8.41

# In the Shadow of Slavery: African Americans in New York City, 1626–1863

Leslie M. Harris

| | |
|---|---|
| WORK | In the Shadow of Slavery: African Americans in New York City, 1626–1863 |
| SELECTION | The Development of the Black Working Class |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages 80-81 · University of Chicago Press, 2003. |

## Excerpt

The vast majority of free blacks in New York City at any one time in the antebellum period were, on the basis of occupation and income alone, part of the working class. However, whites excluded blacks from both the declining artisan trades and the burgeoning metropolitan industrial economy of New York City. Thus, the development of the black working class and of black class consciousness differed from that of whites. Most free blacks, male and female, worked as domestic laborers beginning in 1800, in private homes, hotels, and boarding houses. Black men worked in other service occupations, such as waitering and barbering; and as casual laborers. Black women took in washing. Black men and women also worked as fruit and vegetable peddlers. Perhaps the most steady and highest-paying work available to black working-class men, and to a few women, was maritime work. Most black seamen obtained jobs as stewards or cooks on inland, coastal, or trans-Atlantic voyages; a few black women worked as chambermaids on steamboats. Although such jobs paid comparatively well, black maritime workers had to endure long separations from their families; additionally, their families ashore had to contend with long stretches of time between paychecks.[21]

The low- or irregularly paying occupations that most black adults held meant that children in families served as an important source of additional income. Boarding house and restaurant owners often hired children as helpers. A six-year-old black boy waited on Englishman Henry Bradshaw Fearon during tea at his boarding house. The child was part of a retinue of sixteen servants, of whom only one was white. The others were the servants of the boarding house, and the slaves of southern visitors to New York City.[22] Black child laborers also dominated chimney sweeping. Children, who were small enough to fit into chimneys to clean them, were especially needed. Chimney sweeping was steady, but dangerous, work. Sweeps were subject to broken bones, misshapen limbs, and “Chimney Sweeper’s Cancer” and were sometimes mistreated by sweep masters.[23] Like other forms of child labor, sweeping limited the children’s ability to gain an education. Many of the jobs that black workers held were ones that white workers feared and despised. As slavery ended, blacks were no longer automatically accepted in the skilled workshops of employers who had formerly owned them, if indeed blacks wanted to hold such jobs. As one employer said of his former slave, “The laws set him free and he left me—now let the laws take care of him.” [24] That blacks sought autonomy and that whites were bitter about black freedom led to blacks’ exclusion from many skilled workshops. As free competitors with whites in the job market, free blacks were bound to lose out as white workers refused to work with them and employers easily found wage laborers among the increasing numbers of European immigrants. Black workers did not simply acquiesce to whites’ understanding of their occupational roles. Rather, they claimed varying levels of autonomy in the occupations to which they were limited, negotiating with their employers for their own and their families’ needs. The struggle for cultural and individual autonomy was most difficult for live-in domestic workers. Everyday tensions between live-in domestics and employers sometimes erupted dramatically into arson during the emancipation years, a carryover from methods of rebellion under slavery.[25] But most domestics mediated in less dramatic ways between their desire for autonomy and stability for themselves and their families and the labor needs of the families they served. Some live-in domestic servants managed to convince their employers to help them pay to board their young children with neighbors. A few, such as John Pintard’s servant Hannah, were able to persuade their employers to allow their young children to live with them or to hire relatives or friends. When Hannah left her

position, Pintard hired Tamar, a woman who had worked for him eight years previous and whom he trusted. Tamar capitalized on this trust and Pintard's need by insisting that Pintard hire her daughter Nancy as well, thus increasing the communal wages in her family. Other domestics may have received lesser benefits, such as leftover food or cast-off clothing. Such negotiations for the benefit of their families mitigated, to a degree, domestic servants' lack of autonomy.[26]

Black men and women also actively sought jobs that provided greater autonomy than domestic service. Washerwomen collected laundry at various households but washed the clothes in their own homes. Some washerwomen supplemented their income by taking in the children of domestic workers and other parents who worked outside the home, either on a daily or a longterm basis. Male and female fruit peddlers, ragpickers, cartmen, and day laborers also retained a relatively independent existence. The price of such independence, however, could be unreliable income that threatened economic independence.[27]

## Author's Notes

21. For lives of black maritime workers, see Bolster, Black Jacks. For examples of female maritime workers, see John W. Kennedy Admission Record, Association for the Benefit of Colored Orphans, Admissions of Children, October 1849 to December, 1860, Papers of the Association for the Benefit of Colored Orphans, MS; and Seventeenth Annual Report of the Colored Orphan Asylum (1853), Papers of the Association for the Benefit of Colored Orphans, MS, 8. (Subsequent references to the Association for the Benefit of Colored Orphans, the organization and related source materials, shall appear as ABCO.)

22. Henry Bradshaw Fearon, Sketches of America. A narrative of a journey of five thousand miles through the Eastern and Western states of America; contained in eight reports addressed to the thirty-nine English families by whom the author was deputed, in June 1817, to ascertain whether any, and what part of the United States would be suitable for their residence. With remarks on Mr. Birbeck's "Notes" and "Letters." (London: Longman, Hurst, Rees, Orme, and Brown, 1819), 5– 61, 86 –87. This work appears in [Stokes], "New York City Slums," Notes, 1:317–318.

23. On the conditions of child chimney sweeps, see Phillips, American Chimney Sweeps; Strange, The Climbing Boys; and Pensylvania Society for the Promotion of Public Economy, Report of the Committee on Domestic Economy. See also Gilje and Rock, "'Sweep O! Sweep O!'" 507–519.

24. De Voe, The Market Book, 345.

25. Blackmar, Manhattan for Rent, 116 –120.

26. ABCO, Books of Indentures of ABCO, Package 1, "Birthdates 1829–1853; Admissions 1837–1856 (with some going as late as 1866)" (hereafter cited as ABCO Admission Book 1), Papers of ABCO, MS, passim. The servants of John Pintard are cited in Blackmar, Manhattan for Rent, 116 –120.

27. Stansell, City of Women, 13–14. For a comparison with black women's work in the late nineteenth-century South, see Hunter, To 'Joy My Freedom; and Woodson, "Negro Washerwoman," 269–277.

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Harris, *In the Shadow of Slavery*, 80-81.

CHAPTER 8 · SECONDARY SOURCE S8.42

# In the Shadow of Slavery: African Americans in New York City, 1626–1863

Leslie M. Harris


| | |
|---|---|
| WORK | In the Shadow of Slavery: African Americans in New York City, 1626–1863 |
| SELECTION | White Workers and the Meaning of Black Labor |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages 99-100 · University of Chicago Press, 2003. |


## Excerpt

White workers also feared blacks as symbolic of disquieting changes in the newly industrializing nation. In the early 1800s, changing work processes limited increasing numbers of white male workers to unskilled, lowpaying jobs. Master mechanics began abandoning the apprentice and journeyman systems, hiring unskilled laborers to perform piecework to produce goods. Unskilled men, but especially women and children, put together shoes, clothing, and other articles in large supervised workshops (soon to be known as sweatshops) or at home. Employers paid these workers stingily for their labor so that they could compete nationally and internationally and gain greater profits. These practices led to deskilling among white male apprentices and journeymen who formerly would have been trained to become masters themselves. Instead of preparing these men to own independent shops, masters used them as cheap, unskilled labor. These young men increasingly worked under masters long past the age at which their predecessors would have opened their own shops, for their wages no longer enabled them to save enough money to do so. The Embargo Act of 1807 further clouded their chances for advancement and independence. When merchants were forbidden from trading with Britain, the major market for American goods, workers lost jobs. In New York by 1809, over a thousand men were imprisoned for debt; half of these owed only a week's wages.[6]

Although free blacks were not heavily involved in the new piecework system, their history of enslavement and their current concentration in low-status jobs such as domestic work, chimney sweeping, sailing, and waitering represented symbolically and literally the worst fates that could befall white workers. Blacks themselves symbolized enslavement. Chimney sweeps' sooty appearance and resulting depiction as "black" in British and American accounts no doubt kept whites away from the occupation. Sailing, another occupation that employed large numbers of blacks, was seen as resembling slavery. Sailors since the eighteenth century had been referred to as children and as slaves and carried reputations of immorality and dependency. The discipline aboard ship, especially flogging and impressment, could be interpreted by those on land as depriving sailors of independent political thought. The boarding houses and grogshops that sailors frequented on land were often characterized as places of immorality. Further, the large number of blacks who entered the maritime trades in the late eighteenth and early nineteenth centuries may have degraded the profession in the eyes of whites.[7]

In menial jobs that both blacks and whites held, workers occasionally organized across racial lines. In 1802, black and white New York sailors went on strike for a raise from ten dollars to fourteen dollars a month. In 1853, black and white waiters joined to form a waiters' union and also went on strike for higher wages. But in general New York City's white workers excluded blacks from most jobs in which unions formed and excluded both skilled and unskilled blacks from their organizing activities. Thus, whites excluded blacks from the evolving definition of working-class republicanism and from the practice of white working-class organizing.[8]

## Author's Notes

6. On the changes in skilled labor during this time, see Wilentz, Chants Democratic, 24 – 60; and Sellers, Market Revolution, 21–27. On the embargo and debt imprisonment, see Sellers, Market Revolution, 25.

7. Bolster, Black Jacks, 69–75; Roediger, Wages of Whiteness, 45.

8. On the sailors' strike, see Gilje, Road to Mobocracy, 181. On the waiters' strike, see Philip Foner and Ronald Lewis, The Black Worker to 1869, 191–195. On white workers' exclusion of blacks, see Roediger, Wages of Whiteness, 43– 60, esp. 44 – 46. Implicitly, Sean Wilentz places unskilled jobs, in which the vast majority of black workers and at least half of all other workers participated, outside of his schema of working-class development and consciousness. He focuses on a class of skilled artisans and tradesmen who, by his own accounting, make up for only twofifths to one-half of all employed males in New York City (Wilentz, Chants Democratic, 27n). These figures also exclude working-class women who held jobs outside of the workshops; see Stansell, City of Women. For a work which gives attention to nonartisan workers in New York, see Stott, Workers in the Metropolis.

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### Bibliography entry:

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### Shortened citation:

Harris, *In the Shadow of Slavery*, 99-100.

CHAPTER 8 · SECONDARY SOURCE S8.43

# The Coming of Industrial Order: Town and Factory Life in Rural Massachusetts, 1810–1860

Jonathan Prude

| | |
|---|---|
| WORK | The Coming of Industrial Order: Town and Factory Life in Rural Massachusetts, 1810–1860 |
| SELECTION | The Industrial Order |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages 117-119 · Cambridge University Press, 1983. |

## Excerpt

The work-time separation of children and parents must have affected domestic relations. Far more than the broad, gradually accumulating pressures acting on parent-child relations of farming families, management's intrusions forcefully and directly challenged received notions of parental authority and responsibility. The operatives preserved their families. But in settings where parents controlled neither the work nor tie discipline their children faced during working hours, where both parents and children were subjected to the same overriding managerial control — in such settings parental prestige could only suffer. And this is where claims of paternalism proved so useful. Owners and admirers of country mills like those in Dudley and Oxford asserted that factories could legitimately undermine patriarchy among operatives because they themselves were acting in loco parentis. When pressed to defend their stance more precisely, factory masters sometimes pointed to schools, arguing that mill families "delegated" parental authority to managers just as Yankee households surrendered authority to teachers.º' More often mills simply stressed their "regard" for workers. But in either case, it seems clear that rather than signaling continuity between operative families and the factory regimen, managerial assertions of "interest" and paternalism were invoked to justify managerial interventions between parents and youngsters.

Did any of this work? Did self-interested protestations that factories "showed regard" soften antagonisms toward these establishments? Did grounding labor discipline in moral uplift produce industrious operatives? Did stressing paternalism reduce concern about the domestic disruptions attending factory employment? To some extent, the ideology probably did all this. In Dudley and Oxford the halo of arguments surrounding manufactories by the 1820s and 1830s almost certainly provided at least some counterweight to the suspicions stirred up by factory villages. It quite possibly helped draw some Yankees into millwork (those entering factory jobs out of choice, for example), and it may well have encouraged these recruits to work diligently and without complaint during their stints.

But the suspicions were at most modified, not eradicated. Despite the mill masters' ideology, local operatives and townspeople still felt a strong — even growing — ambivalence toward the mills. Indeed, what requires notice at this point is that the ideology itself could generate alarm. A vision of paternalistic factory villages might strike sympathetic commentators as idyllic, as a conception underscoring the progressive potential of textile mills. But to those who viewed factory villages less as arenas for social therapy and more as merely places to live and work, the notion could have different implications.

It could, for example, make mill villages appear curiously anachronistic. Even while factory enclaves were introducing an architectural scale, social order, and demographic density that stood out dramatically in the postrevolutionary Yankee countryside, there is a sense in which their description as a "large and well-conducted family" could provoke nostalgic memories. By emphasizing the closeknit quality of mill life, by stressing how factory hands operated under the authority of a few officials, the paternalistic motif signaled ways in which manufactories more closely paralleled the more centralized and consistently hierarchical society of seventeenth and early eighteenth century rural New England than the fluid, physically dispersed, and lightly governed townships of the late eighteenth

and early nineteenth centuries. Invoking paternalism, in other words, could make mill villages seem like throwbacks to an earlier age.

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**Shortened citation:**

Prude, *The Coming of Industrial Order*, 117-119.

CHAPTER 8 · SECONDARY SOURCE S8.44

# The Coming of Industrial Order: Town and Factory Life in Rural Massachusetts, 1810–1860

Jonathan Prude

| | |
|---|---|
| WORK | The Coming of Industrial Order: Town and Factory Life in Rural Massachusetts, 1810–1860 |
| SELECTION | Operative Resistance |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages 141-142 · Cambridge University Press, 1983. |

## Excerpt

Thus developed a kind of balance. The increased stress on forms of opposition that permitted continued employment in the mills, and especially the emergence of collaborative efforts to distinguish normal from "extra" demands, suggest that many operatives were coming to accept the factory order but simultaneously modifying the regimen with their own requirements. Accepting factory life on these terms — this giving and taking between employers and employees, this tugging back and forth in ways both sides could more or less accept but which also underscored the differences between them — this was an established pattern in local mill villages by 1820.

The incident arose because the South Village imposed a wage cut on its cassimere handloom weavers. The competitive pressures that forced general piece-rate reductions among handloom weavers during the 1820s led finally, in the spring of 1827, to a cut that the skilled weavers working inside Slater's woolen compound found intolerable. The precise size of the reduction is not known. But it was evidently too large to be either accepted or offset by managerial compromise in other areas of factory life. The affected weavers (as Slater reported to the Dudley Woolen Manufacturing Company) announced their "determination not to weave unless at the old prices": in other words, to strike."

The South Village "turnout" in 1827 should be viewed in two ways. First, as the consequence of pressures playing across life and work in Slater's woolen village, the strike did not arise ex nihilo or even merely as a response to a wage cut. The weavers' "determination" derived in part from their position as skilled workers who had not been promoted from below and so felt no particular debt to management. More than most millworkers, they had a sense of customary worth and status; and thus, more than most, they were prepared to protest sharp economic demotions. Doubtless too, the South Village weavers drew inspiration from the general rise of labor militancy in antebellum northern cities like Philadelphia, New York, and Boston. Indeed, the operatives' transiency makes it likely that South Village weavers had learned from events in other mills: the 1824 strike in Pawtucket, for example, which marked the first full-scale American textile turnout."° But most of all, the 1827 confrontation arose from the long-building momentum of resistance — the tradition of individual gestures, the collaborative insistence on "extra" pay for "extra" work — brewing within the mill villages of Dudley and Oxford. Despite the short stints of local operatives, the heritage of defiant gestures, and the boundaries that had been established around acceptable managerial demands and acceptable employee performances —~ all this was preserved from year to year and communicated to any employee entering the manufactories. This heritage and these boundaries were the points of departure for the 1827 strike.

In this sense the South Village incident illuminates a pattern common in the labor confrontations of America's early industrial era. For throughout the opening decades of the nineteenth century, strikes typically emerged out of lengthy struggles between employees and employers to establish the lines and limits of their relationship. As in the South Village, so in other workplaces experiencing turnouts, strikes were usually conservative efforts to forestall changes — whether wage cuts or changes in working hours or (sometimes seemingly trivial) amendments in work rules — that

employees felt went too far too fast: as though a threshold had been reached that laborers were unwilling to cross without a struggle. But as in the South Village also, such eruptions of militancy were usually shaped by — indeed, are comprehensible only in light of — lengthy prior histories of fencing between workers and their employers."

## Chicago Citations

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Prude, *The Coming of Industrial Order*, 141-142.

CHAPTER 8 · SECONDARY SOURCE S8.45

# The Market Revolution: Jacksonian America, 1815-1846

Charles Sellers

| | |
|---|---|
| WORK | The Market Revolution: Jacksonian America, 1815-1846 |
| SELECTION | Land and Market |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages 5-6 · Oxford University Press, 1991. |

## Excerpt

But New World land closed the interior to the market it galvanized at tidewater. Moving goods was infinitely more difficult across the thinly inhabited reaches of America than in densely populated Europe. Beyond water transportation, bulky farm products had to be wagoned over scarcely maintained and often impassable roads and trails. Hauling them more than thirty or forty miles cost more than they were worth. Consequently people who settled at any distance from navigable water mainly produced use values for subsistence rather than the market's commodity values for sale.

Profound cultural differences arose from these contrasting modes of production. The market fostered individualism and competitive pursuit of wealth by open-ended production of commodity values that could be accumulated as money. But rural production of use values stopped once bodies were sheltered and clothed and bellies provided for. Surplus produce had no abstract or money value, and wealth could not be accumulated. Therefore the subsistence culture fostered family obligation, communal cooperation, and reproduction over generations of a modest comfort.

During the eighteenth century a demographic explosion swelled this subsistence-farming sector into a major historical force. Low mortality and the fecundity of colonial mothers, combining with a new surge of immigrants displaced from the market's European core, sent population flooding into the interior. By the end of the century, a majority of free Americans lived in a distinctive subsistence culture remote from river navigation and the market world.

By 1815, however, a market revolution was surmounting the overland transportation barrier. While dissolving deeply rooted patterns of behavior and belief for competitive effort, it mobilized collective resources through government to fuel growth in countless ways, not least by providing the essential legal, financial, and transport infrastructures. Establishing capitalist hegemony over economy, politics, and culture the market revalutian created aurcelvec and mnet af the warld we The stressed and resistant Jacksonian majority has eluded or baffled our historiography of consensual, democratic capitalism. Despite contradictions of patriarchy, racism, and fee-simple property, they rallied around enduring human values of family, trust, cooperation, love, and equality. Understanding of both the world they lost and the world we have gained begins with understanding differences between the cultures of land and market.* The New World's ancient immigrants, people of the land par excellence, throw into sharpest relief the cultural gulf separating land from market. Bark lodges in the eastern woodlands, tipis on the plains, pueblos in the arid southwest, and igloos on the Arctic ice typified Native Americans' ingenious adaptations to varied ecological niches. Through ancient human techniques of hunting, gathering, fishing, and planting, these mainly Indian peoples extracted their subsistence directly from the land. Their only domesticated animal was the dog until the European horse reached the plains, but they had brought their maize/vegetable polyculture to a high level of sophistication. Like other premarket ecological adaptations, the Indian mode of production furnished adequate subsistence without onerous labor.

But Marx's European analysis requires considerable adaptation to the special circumstances flowing from cheap American land—widespread property ownership, a farming populace oriented more to subsistence than profit, and a bourgeoisie massively reinforced by small enterprisers. Here the industrial capitalism of commodified wage labor

was not possible until merchant capital pushed a market revolution across the countryside to transform economy, culture, and politics by commodifying the family labor of subsistence producers. “Market,” in this capitalist sense, excludes local exchange for subsistence while including production for a competitive world market with commodified slave labor. Only on the battlefields of the Civil War did the progressive bourgeoisie of free-labor exploitation finally prevail over resistant farmers, workers, and the anachronistic planter bourgeoisie of slave-labor exploitation.

## Chicago Citations

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**Shortened citation:**

Sellers, *The Market Revolution*, 5-6.

CHAPTER 8 · SECONDARY SOURCE S8.46

# The Market Revolution: Jacksonian America, 1815-1846

Charles Sellers

| | |
|---|---|
| WORK | The Market Revolution: Jacksonian America, 1815-1846 |
| SELECTION | Artisans and Capitalist Production |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages 25-26 · Oxford University Press, 1991. |

## Excerpt

Journeyman mechanics, with their tradition of skills and craft pride, fought back. They began excluding masters from journeymen's societies organized in the various crafts to defend labor against capital. Isolated strikes by journeymen are recorded as far back as 1768. The first journeymen's society clearly designed to protect wages—the first labor union in the modern sense—was organized by Philadelphia shoemakers at the beginning of the commercial boom in 1794, and a surge of journeymen organizations and strikes filled the boom years. Employers eventually resorted to the courts. Hard times and the conviction of striking shoemakers for conspiracy at Philadelphia in 1806 and New York in 1810 quelled worker militancy for a decade.[32]

Masters, too, felt threatened by capitalist relations of production. When "wealthy capitalists" built an enormous bakehouse in New York to mass-produce bread with wage labor, three hundred mechanics met to declare solidarity with besieged neighborhood bakers. The Bread Company's backers, charged "A Mechanic," intended to "monopolize by degrees all profitable mechanical branches." Their large capital would enable them to buy flour cheaper, or to forego profits temporarily, so as to undersell and drive out of business any "obstinate mechanics... unwilling to become servants." They would then hire hundreds of mechanics at miserly wages, reserving for themselves the extra profits. "They will screw down the wages to the last thread," this prophetic newspaper essayist asserted. "Next, the independent spirit, so distinguished at present in our mechanics, and so useful in republics, will be entirely annihilated. The workmen will be servants and slaves." This crisis was resolved by destruction of the bakehouse in a fire of undetermined origin.[33]

While deskilling and proletarianizing a majority of the urban working class, market growth opened unprecedented opportunities for a minority. Masters who commanded the capital to exploit more wage labor energized market revolution as nascent manufacturers. New York's tax assessments identify many of these successful masters. The potter Clarkson Crolius increased his taxable worth from $8,300 in 1808 to $11,400 in 1815, while the holdings of the baker Thomas Mercein rose from $2,600 to $11, i oo. The 1815 assessments included a tailor worth $15,900, a shoemaker worth $18,300, and two builders worth $49,500 and $9,100. Success on an even greater scale enabled some masters to push through the status boundary into gentility. Particularly inspiring to the upwardly mobile was Stephen Allen, who began as a penniless apprentice sailmaker, had his own sailmaking partnership by the time he was twenty-one, and ended worth $32,000 and occupying the gentleman's position of mayor. Painter and glazier Jacob Sherred accumulated assets valued at $izo,ooo. Tanner Jacob Lorrilard, beginning business with a $3,000 loan from wealthy relatives in 1800, owned $90,700 worth of property by 1815, including three houses, two leather stores, and forty acres of Manhattan real estate. Noah Brown, a "barefoot frontier boy" who began as an unknown journeyman shipwright, became a prominent shipbuilder. His activity in Republican politics eased his way upward, doubtless helping him obtain during the War of 1812 a $200,000 navy contract on which he employed over two hundred men. The famous cabinetmaker Duncan Phyfe almost went broke after he served his apprenticeship and opened a small shop. Saved by the patronage of John Jacob Astor's daughter, he developed a large shop and elegant salesroom and was eventually worth $500,000. Phyfe's elaborate display for the 1815 peace celebration won newspaper praise along with that of eminent gentlemen.

## Author's Notes

32. Charles Sellers, "The Equilibrium Cycle in Two-Party Politics," Public Opinion Quarterly xy (Spring 1965), 16-38, quotation 30; William H. Riker, The Theory of Political Coalitions (New Haven, i 962).

33. Richard P. McCormick, The Second American Party System: Party Formation in the Jacksonian Era (Chapel Hill, i 966), especially 3-31, 329-56; Richard P. McCormick, The Presidential Game: The Origins of American Presidential Politics (New York, 1982).

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**Shortened citation:**

Sellers, *The Market Revolution*, 25-26.

CHAPTER 8 · SECONDARY SOURCE S8.47

# The Market Revolution: Jacksonian America, 1815-1846

Charles Sellers

| | |
|---|---|
| WORK | The Market Revolution: Jacksonian America, 1815-1846 |
| SELECTION | Market Discipline and the Household |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages 239-240 · Oxford University Press, 1991. |

## Excerpt

Middling New York City Brooklyn Philadelphia Boston Upward mobility was somewhat greater in booming smaller places and among mechanic/manufacturers; and many workers climbed from rags to threadbare respectability. But general mobility was limited. The rise from rags to riches was statistically mythical, at least as crudely measured by Philadelphians' changes in status of occupation and neighborhood. Few moved more than one rung up a multirunged social ladder, many fell from wealth, and more into poverty.[4] Across the North in the 1810s these sharpening realities of class coincided with middle-class mythology to threaten patriarchal families with shame of failure. Economic vicissitude, widely experienced and exemplified, made all classes susceptible to the cultural imperialism of the bourgeoisie. Pulpit, schoolroom, and a rising tide of print—drowning out radical antinomians, democrats, and laborites—dinned in middle-class myth and ethic. Many a dislocated worker or farmer, getting "little pity in his poverty," struggled for middle-class status as the only socially available strategy for saving patriarchal honor. While middle-class effort propelled some into bourgeois success, and a few to opulence, most managed only a precarious respectability while giving their all to capitalist production. In the crucible of the middle-class family, a culture mobilizing effort forged itself for instinctual repression. While a militant temperance movement publicly demanded self-discipline, impulse was privately fought at its deepest springs in gender and libido. The task fell to families under demographic stress. As never before, young adults and nuclear households were forsaking kin and neighborhood to wander from place to place. Population changes identify two great migratory tides, one flowing from East to West and the other from country to town or city. But a far greater tide of to-and-fro migration was required to produce the impressive net changes. In the best-studied example, less than half the Bostonians counted by the census of 1830 were still there ten years later. The 1836 city directory expunged 24 percent of the households listed the previous year. Some died, of course, but the vast majority moved on. An amazing 3,325,000 people passed through Boston between 1830 and 1890 to produce a net population growth of 387,000. Less exact evidence suggests similar turnover in smaller towns and rural areas. The movers were mainly the poor in search of a better livelihood, and they often moved considerable distances. In this great uprooting, the peripatetic dispersal of Prophet Joseph Smith's clan was all too typical.[5]

The uprooted, insular household found children no longer an asset but an impediment to survival. Their labor on shrunken farms no longer earned their keep; they challenged a paternal authority that could no longer provide them with farms or livelihood; and they required a more rigorous socialization for market competition. Under these pressures Americans inaugurated history's most dramatic and sustained repression of human fertility. For more than a century, births per i,000 whites declined, from 55.0 in 1800 to 43.3 by 1850 and 10.6 by 1930. The number of children born per married woman fell from 6.4 in 1800 to 4.9 by 1850 and 2.8 by 1880. This revolutionary "demographic transition" eventually spread with industrialization and urbanization across the North Atlantic world and then to Japan and other countries. But only in the United States, where the birth rate noticeably declined first and farthest, did the demographic transition spread through a mainly rural people before a sharp mortality decline and before large-scale industrialization/urbanization. Only here was it so clearly associated (as ever more sophisticated tests confirm) with the rising price of land. The transatlantic contrast arose from contrasting person/land ratios. Fertility was eroded at very different rates in the Old and New Worlds, first by land scarcity and

then by industrial/urban imperatives. The land-scarcity stage occurred gradually and inconspicuously over several centuries in crowded, commercializing western Europe; and only in the late nineteenth century did the industrial/urban stage bring the conspicuous further downturn of the demographic transition. By contrast, North American cheap land kept births high until the market revolution surmounted the transport barrier and forced Americans to cope overnight with stresses that Europeans experienced over centuries. The American demographic transition telescoped the land-scarcity stage of fertility decline into a generation or two before merging imperceptibly into the industrial/urban stage. Births declined first in the Moderate Light's southeastern New England heartland in the last quarter of the eighteenth century, and then across the countryside as local land became too expensive to provide farms for numerous offspring and cheap land receded beyond easy reach with western settlement and rising farmmaking costs. Threatened by shame of paternal failure, a straitened patriarchy constrained itself. The land-scarcity stage of fertility control penetrated the South and West as the Northeast entered the industrial/urban stage. New England's fertility reduction of 1800 reached the upper South in 1820 and remote Michigan and Wisconsin in 18 50. By then births in still more remote Arkansas and Oregon were falling to the somewhat higher 1800 level of the Middle Atlantic states. Meanwhile Massachusetts was entering the industrial/urban stage as education and the calculating rationality of bourgeois culture began to exert greater pressure on fertility than land scarcity.[6]

## Author's Notes

4. Edward Pessen, Riches, Class, and Power before the Civil War (Lexington, Mass., 1973), especially 77-91; Stuart M. Blumin, "Mobility and Change in Ante-Bellum Philadelphia," in Stephan Thernstrom and Richard Sennett, eds., Nineteenth-Century Cities: Essays in the New Urban History (New Haven, i 969), 165-2.08.

5. Stephan Thernstrom and Peter R. Knights, "Men in Motion: Some Data and Speculations about Urban Population Mobility in Nineteenth-Century America," journal of Interdisciplinary History i (Autumn 1970): 7-35.

6. Robert V. Wells, Uncle Sam's Family: Issues and Perspectives in American Demographic History (Albany, 1985), 28-56; Robert V. Wells, Revolution in Americans' Lives: A Demographic Perspective on the History of Americans, Their Families, and Their Society (Westport, 19 8 z), 93; Maris A. Vinovskis, Fertility in Massachusetts from the Revolution to the Civil War (New York, 1981); Morton O. Schapiro, "Land Availability and Fertility in the United States, 1760- r 870," Journal of Economic History 42 (Sept. 1982): 577-600.

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**Shortened citation:**

Sellers, *The Market Revolution*, 239-240.

CHAPTER 8 · SECONDARY SOURCE S8.48

# From Market-Places to a Market Economy: The Transformation of Rural Massachusetts, 1750–1850

Winifred Barr Rothenberg

| | |
|---|---|
| WORK | From Market-Places to a Market Economy: The Transformation of Rural Massachusetts, 1750–1850 |
| SELECTION | Introduction |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages xii-xiv · University of Chicago Press, 1992. |

## Excerpt

This book had its beginnings in an attempt directly to measure the growth of an agricultural economy on the cutting edge of transforming change: rural Massachusetts between 1750 and 1850. The problem, as I initially formulated it, was to estimate for a sample of farms inventoried at probate a set of production functions, by which is meant the quantitative relations between farm outputs, on the one hand, and land, labor, and capital (working livestock and farm tools) inputs, on the other. Data problems proved to be serious, not the least of which was to construct an index with which to deflate probate values in order to avoid confounding real changes with fluctuations in the purchasing power of the currency.

It was in the course of constructing a deflator relevant to that economy—composed of the products raised by those farmers, constructed from farm-gate prices charged by those farmers, and weighted by the relative importance of each of those products to Massachusetts farmers—that two observations struck me as particularly significant: regional differentials in the price of corn appeared to narrow (converge) over time; and the farm price index, once constructed, appeared to exhibit a pattern of cyclical fluctuations and sudden shocks synchronous with those observed in the Warren-Pearson index of New York City wholesale prices and the Bezanson index of Philadelphia wholesale prices. Synchronicity and convergence in the behavior of prices is an acknowledged diagnostic of the role of market forces in their determination. In the light of the social historiography dominant in the last two decades, which would deny to market forces a hegemonic role in the preindustrial economy of New England, I felt compelled to pursue a line of inquiry that, while closely related to productivity growth, is nonetheless different from it. When did the rural economy of Massachusetts become 'market oriented'? How can we know? What role did market orientation play in the transformation of the rural economy; that is, what were its productivity consequences? In the end, the effort to document the emergence of a market economy would prove not to have been a digression at all but to have come around full circle not only to a measure of labor productivity growth but also to an explanation for it.

## Chicago Citations

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Winifred Barr Rothenberg, *From Market-Places to a Market Economy: The Transformation of Rural Massachusetts, 1750–1850* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1992), xii-xiv.

**Shortened citation:**

Rothenberg, *From Market-Places to a Market Economy*, xii-xiv.

CHAPTER 8 · SECONDARY SOURCE S8.49

# From Market-Places to a Market Economy: The Transformation of Rural Massachusetts, 1750–1850

Winifred Barr Rothenberg

| | |
|---|---|
| WORK | From Market-Places to a Market Economy: The Transformation of Rural Massachusetts, 1750–1850 |
| SELECTION | Conclusion |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages Conclusion (supplied PDF 285) · University of Chicago Press, 1992. |

## Excerpt

Shops and stores constitute significant nodes in a dendritic marketing network.*? When, around 1800, the little inland town of Shrewsbury found a market in Boston— ninety miles away—for its cheese, butter, chickens, veal, pork, and hay and in Brighton for its cattle, it was in large measure because Artemas Ward's general store was a node in a proliferating network of symbiotic enterprises stretching from Worcester County to Boston along the two roads that ran through Shrewsbury. Stores, and peddlers as well, not only expanded the marketing perimeters of farmers qua suppliers but also played an important role in fashioning among farmers a demand for store-bought goods the insatiability of which may very well have been one of the "kicks" that got agriculture moving.

## Chicago Citations

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Winifred Barr Rothenberg, *From Market-Places to a Market Economy: The Transformation of Rural Massachusetts, 1750–1850* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1992), Conclusion (supplied PDF 285).

**Shortened citation:**

Rothenberg, *From Market-Places to a Market Economy*, Conclusion (supplied PDF 285).

CHAPTER 8 · SECONDARY SOURCE S8.50

# The Alcoholic Republic: An American Tradition

W. J. Rorabaugh

| | |
|---|---|
| WORK | The Alcoholic Republic: An American Tradition |
| SELECTION | The Pursuit of Happiness |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages 176-177 · Oxford University Press, 1979. |

## Excerpt

In these countries the popularity of distilled spirits at particular times signified high aspirations combined with low motivation for achievement. Motivation was low because these were traditional societies. High aspirations, however, could lead to changes that would raise motivation, and high motivation, as social psychologist David McClelland has stated, is an indicator of future economic growth. I would hypothesize that when industrial expansion begins, motivation to succeed is necessarily low, rooted in peasant values that stress the virtue and safety of tradition. As economic development leads to success in meeting targets, confidence in the ability to attain goals grows. This increase in motivation, combined with a narrowing of the gap between aspirations and achievement, reduces anxieties, at least for those social and economic classes that achieve success. Consequently, many people who have drunk distilled spirits become abstainers. After 1825, when the United States enjoyed accelerating economic growth, the temperance movement flourished, particularly among the middle classes that were the principal beneficiaries of prosperity. Similar developments can be observed in the industrialization of Great Britain and Scandinavia. It might also be noted that in the United States after 1840, as factory workers whose dead-end jobs discouraged both motivation and aspirations became more numerous, the consumption of beer increased.[36]

## Author's Notes

36. David C. McClelland, *The Achieving Society* (Princeton, 1961). See chapter 3, note 40, and appendix 2.

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W. J. Rorabaugh, *The Alcoholic Republic: An American Tradition* (New York: Oxford University Press, 1979), 176-177.

**Shortened citation:**

Rorabaugh, *The Alcoholic Republic*, 176-177.

CHAPTER 8 · SECONDARY SOURCE S8.51

# The Alcoholic Republic: An American Tradition

W. J. Rorabaugh

| | |
|---|---|
| WORK | The Alcoholic Republic: An American Tradition |
| SELECTION | Demon Rum |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages 194-195 · Oxford University Press, 1979. |

## Excerpt

One reason for the popularity of temperance societies in the 1820s was that they satisfied many patriotic longings. Antiliquor reformers asked Americans to draft temperance society constitutions, sign pledges, and celebrate their dry oaths on the 4th of July. These actions were analogous to those that the Founding Fathers had taken a half century earlier. The symbolism was explicit, as shown by the frequent references that temperance advocates made to the struggle for independence. They argued that abstinence from liquor required as much virtue as had fighting the British during the Revolution, that it demanded the same kind of sacrifice as renouncing British tea in 1773, and that the early temperance movement, though a failure, had prepared them for the present struggle just as the French and Indian War had prepared the colonists to fight the Revolution. Some reformers drew a closer parallel to the Revolution. At one 4th of July celebration, a speaker declared that when future generations assembled to honor the Founding Fathers, they would be able to say, 'On this day, also did our fathers, of a later generation, declare and maintain a SECOND INDEPENDENCE.' Another group of abstainers read a version of the Declaration in which George III was replaced by Prince Alcohol. Uses of symbolism and analogy were particularly popular in 1826, during the celebration of the fiftieth anniversary of the nation's birth. Americans apparently felt the need to be reborn, to be baptized anew in a struggle for liberty and equality, to be reassured by each other that they were worthy descendants of the Founding Fathers. They, too, needed a Revolution; so they pledged their lives, their fortunes, and their sacred honor in the war against Prince Alcohol.[6]

## Author's Notes

6. Eliakim Phelps, *Intemperance* (Geneva, N.Y., 1830), 20; Elisha Mitchell, *Arguments for Temperance* (Raleigh, N.C., 1831), 29; and contemporary temperance-society reports cited in the supplied edition.

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